

BIRDMAN

Written by

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Based on, If Any

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BLACK

We hear a clock ticking.

FADE IN:

1 INT. RIGGAN'S DRESSING ROOM - THEATER - DAY

1

Close on the brilliant colors of a middle eastern rug, the center of what seems to be a makeshift "meditation" space.

We slowly tilt up to discover the back of Riggan Thomson (55). He is in the proper 'Lotus' position, dressed only in tight white briefs and he appears to be meditating deeply. And if all this seems a little odd, it becomes all the more so when you notice that he is levitating almost two feet above the floor. His breath is calm and measured... in and out... in and out.

MAN (V.O.)

How did we end up here?

(Beat.)

This place is a fucking dump.

We begin to slowly move toward Riggan's back while his measure breathing continues. We see a clock on the wall, ticking.

MAN (V.O.)

Smells like balls.

A slight twitch in Riggan's neck.

MAN (V.O.)

We don't belong in this shithole.

A Skype call shatters the silence. Close on his back, we follow Riggan as he walks over to the computer and answers the call.

On the computer screen appears Sam (21), in a pair of Levi's and a Led Zeppelin T-shirt. She has simple and striking good looks, with an edge in her voice and behind her eyes. She stands in a Korean Deli among the flowers, talking to Riggan through her iPhone.

The Korean Store owner (50) stands in the background screaming at her the whole time.

RIGGAN

Sam, I can't--

SAM

Dad? What kind of--
 (Turning to Korean.)
 SHUT UP!!!
 (Back to screen.)
 What kind of flowers did you say
 you wanted?

RIGGAN
 Alchemillas. Or something soothing
 that smells nice. Listen I can't--

SAM
 It all smells like fucking Kimchi !

RIGGAN
 Then whatever looks nice. Anything
 but roses. No roses.

KOREAN
 Flowers don't need you touch! They
 need you buy!!!

SAM
 (Close into the screen.)
 I hate this job.

And the Skype call is over. Riggan closes the laptop and leans forward trying to regain his calm. His reflection appears in the mirror, and for the first time we see his face. He has a dark goatee and his hair looks strangely abundant. There is a piece of paper on the mirror with the handwritten phrase "A thing is a thing, not what it is said of that thing."

ANNIE ON SPEAKERS
 Riggan, they're starting scene
 five. We need you on stage.

RIGGAN
 Shit...

Riggan throws on a sweater and stumbles into his slacks. He hurries out...

2 INT. HALLWAYS - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

2

...through the narrow corridors of the theater. There is a lot of activity as various workers and stage hands appear and disappear carrying equipment and scenery. As Riggan descends the stairs, a Stage Hand• passes by in the opposite direction.

STAGE HAND•

Mr. Thomson.

RIGGAN
Steve.

STAGE HAND
It's Daniel.

RIGGAN
(Already passed.)
Okay.

Riggan continues on until he arrives backstage. He runs into Jake (42) his producer and friend.

JAKE
How's it going, buddy.

RIGGAN
Great. It'd be even better if I could get Ralph to stop acting like he's in an educational video for syphilis...

The camera moves off of them and onto...

3 INT. STAGE - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

3

...the stage. Suddenly we are in the midst of an Americana style kitchen.

Around the kitchen table sit Lesley (35), plain and no nonsense, her simple hairstyle and makeup can't hide how attractive she is. Laura (35), dark, exotic, the kind of woman who makes every person she meets feel like she's seducing them. And Ralph (40), slightly handsome, slightly balding, slightly invisible.

A half empty bottle of gin on the table, they drink from highball glasses as they chat...

LESLEY
He loved me.

RALPH
Yeah. He loved her so much he tried to kill her.

LAURA
He tried to kill you?

LESLEY
No.

(A beat.)

Okay, well, he did beat me up one night. He dragged me around the living room by my ankles, yelling "I love you, I love you, bitch." What do you do with a love like that?

RALPH

How is that-- That is not love and you know it. Why do you insist on calling it--

LESLEY

You can say what you want, but I know what it was.

RALPH

What about you, Nick? Does that sound like love to you?

Riggan arrives at the table and sits.

RIGGAN

Sorry I'm late.

(Beat. In character.)

I'm the wrong person to ask. I didn't know the man. I've only heard his name mentioned in passing. You'd have to know the particulars. But I think what you're saying is that love is absolute.

RALPH

Yeah. The kind of love I'm talking about is... The kind of love I'm talking about, you don't try and kill people.

LESLEY

(Sadly.)

It was love, Mel. To Eddie, it was. I don't care what anybody says. He was ready to die for it.

RALPH

Ask her what he did after she left him.

LESLEY

He shot himself in the mouth. But he screwed that up, too. Poor Ed.

RALPH

Poor Ed, my ass. The guy was dangerous.

LAURA

How'd he screw it up if he shot himself in the mouth?

RALPH

(By the numbers.)

He used to carry this twenty-two.
We lived like fugitives those days.
I never knew--

RIGGAN

(Breaking character to direct. Exasperated.)

Okay. Fugitives are on the run,
Ralph. How many times do I have to--
- Fugitives are scared. Give me more of that.

Ralph nods. He takes a breath and dives in once again...

RALPH

(The same but louder.)

We lived like fugitives those days...

Extremely frustrated, Riggan stares out into the auditorium. From his POV we see Jake who is now sitting in the third row. His head buried in his hands, tortured by Ralph's performance. Riggan turns back to Ralph.

RALPH (CONT'D)

...I never knew if he was going to come out of the bushes or from behind a car and just start shooting.

Riggan watches Ralph act and sees his whole production headed down the drain. Ralph is just that bad.

RALPH (CONT'D)

The man was crazy. He was capable of anything.

The actors all wait for a cue from Riggan, who is now staring up into the lights above the stage. Laura finally picks up Riggan's cue.

LAURA

Christ. What a nightmare...

RALPH
He used to call me at the hospital
and say...
(Over the top.)
"Son of a bitch. Your days are
numbered."

Silence. Ralph looks over to Riggan.

RALPH (CONT'D)
Too much? Little bit? I just wanted
to give you a range, so you could--

And with that a light comes barreling down from it's perch
and crashes into Ralph's head, making him hit the floor like
a rag doll. Silence.

LAURA
Holy shit.

Lesley and Annie (35), the Stage Manager, run over to Ralph
who is out cold. Not knowing what to do, they stare at him.

LESLEY
Is he breathing?

Jake runs toward the stage.

JAKE
Someone call 911!

Riggan slowly backs away from the chaos.

LAURA
Is that blood coming out of his
ear?

JAKE
(To Riggan.)
Where are you going?

LESLEY
Okay, he's breathing. What did he
have for lunch?

LAURA
Did anyone call for help?

ANNIE
(Clapping.)
Wake up! Wake up!

Two crew members try to help Ralph.

CREW MEMBER
Grab his legs. I got the top.

JAKE
Don't move him! Wait for the
ambulance.
(Calling out.)
For the love of God! I could get a
black audience in this theater
faster than a doctor!

Riggan heads off the stage, and Jake chases after him. We follow them as...

4 INT. HALLWAY - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

4

...they walk through the corridor.

JAKE
Where are you going? We'll have the
understudy ready to rehearse in
five--

RIGGAN
Forget the understudy. We have to
postpone the preview.

JAKE
What are you-- It's a full house.
We would have to refund all the--

RIGGAN
Then do it.

A crew member• passes in the opposite direction.

CREW MEMBER•
How's Ralph?

RIGGAN
He'll be fine.

JAKE
Wait. Wait. Fuck. Wait.

RIGGAN
Listen to me. It was going to be a
disaster. That guy's the worst
actor I've ever seen. The blood
coming out of his ear was the most
honest thing he's done so far.

JAKE

He's not that bad.

Riggan stops in his tracks and stares at Jake.

JAKE (CONT'D)

Okay, he's fucking horrible. But--

Riggan starts walking again.

JAKE (CONT'D)

You have the press in your dressing room in a few hours. How are we--

RIGGAN

I'll make something up.

Two Technicians• hurry up in the opposite direction.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)

Jake This happened for a reason. It wasn't an accident.

JAKE

What do you mean?

RIGGAN

I--

(A beat.)

I made it happen.

JAKE

Oh. Okay.

(Beat.)

Are you drunk?

RIGGAN

Find me an actor. A good actor. Philip Seymour Hoffman...

JAKE

He's doing the third Hunger Games.

RIGGAN

Michael Fassbender?

JAKE

Doing the prequel to the X-Men prequel.

They arrive at Riggan's dressing room.

RIGGAN

What's his name? Jeremy Renner...

JAKE

Who?

RIGGAN

The... the Hurt Locker guy.

JAKE

Yeah. He's an Avenger.

RIGGAN

(With disgust.)

Fuck. They put him in a cape, too?

(A beat.)

Look, I don't care. Find me someone.

Riggan enters...

5 INT. RIGGAN'S DRESSING ROOM - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

5

...his dressing room and tries to shut the door. Jake, still in the corridor, stops it with his foot.

JAKE

(Sticking his head in.)

Ralph'll sue us. He'll sue us. And he's got a case.

Riggan releases the door.

RIGGAN

Then make him go away.

JAKE

How do you suggest I do that?

RIGGAN

You're my lawyer, my producer and my oldest friend. We are going to make this work. Now just get out there and do what you were born to do.

JAKE

What's that?

RIGGAN

I have no idea. But I have faith. Now go away from me.

JAKE

Do you think we should--

Riggan slams the door shut on Jake. A beat. On a television, a segment of E! News. A busty blond, with an exaggerated smile, hosts.

BLOND WOMAN

...and when we come back, an exclusive interview with Robert Downey Jr., who tells us about the billion-dollar Iron Man franchise. The talented actor invited us onto the set of Iron Man 3...

Riggan slams the tv off, his mind racing. He sits on a chair.

MAN (V.O.)

That clown doesn't have half your talent and he's making a fortune in that Tin Man get up.

Riggan stares into the mirror, in the reflection he catches sight of a poster from a movie called "Birdman 3". The superhero, Birdman (a younger Riggan in a bird costume), wings widely spread, stares directly back at him. A handwritten note on the top of the poster reads: "Thomson, break a wing! From the boys at Local 1." Riggan tries to calm himself with a mantra...

RIGGAN

"Breathing in, I embrace my anger.
Breathing out, I smile to it."

BIRDMAN (V.O.)

Embrace it. Kiss it. Turn it around
and fuck it in the--

A knock on the door behind him.

RIGGAN

Not now!

Laura opens the door and sticks her head in.

LAURA

Can I come in?

RIGGAN

No.

LAURA

Okay. Two words. Shia La Beouf.

RIGGAN

That's three words.

LAURA
It's two.

RIGGAN
Get out.

LAURA
I love you.

She closes the door. Riggan tries to calm himself down, but Laura opens the door again.

LAURA (CONT'D)
I take it we're not going to dinner anymore?

RIGGAN
I don't have an actor.

LAURA
I don't have a life.

RIGGAN
Laura...

LAURA
Fine. Whatever.
(Goes to leave but stops.)
You remember at Joan's when you asked me to come do a Broadway play with you? You said it would be fun...

RIGGAN
Go away.

LAURA
So far? No fun.

Riggan closes the door and looks at the Birdman poster.

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
Fun? You know what would be fun?
Getting the fuck out of here before we humiliate ourselves. That would be fun.

Riggan looks at himself in the mirror and begins to pull at his hair. As it comes off his head, we discover it was a wig. He turns away from the mirror, trying desperately to stay calm. Something catches his eye: a vase of roses on the end of the table. A card in them says, "They didn't have the whatever you wanted - Sam". Enraged, Riggan focuses on the vase. It begins to shift. Then, with a surge of anger, without ever touching it, he sends it crashing against the wall on the other side of the room.

The camera pans over the roses scattered across the floor. It hovers over the carpet and around the perimeter of the room, until it finally settles on Riggan, now dressed in a casual blazer.

It is later the same day. He is sitting on the sofa and on three chairs in front of him are three journalists:

Gabriel, a geeky theatre journalist, wearing thick glasses and a thin tie. Clara, a reporter from an entertainment blog. And Han, a polite, obese Japanese journalist, who sits next to his translator, another Japanese guy.

GABRIEL

Why does somebody go from playing the lead in a comic book franchise to adapting Raymond Carver for the stage?

Riggan tries to remain calm.

GABRIEL (CONT'D)

I mean, as you're probably aware, Barthes said, "The cultural work done in the past by gods and epic sagas is now done by laundry detergent commercials and comic strip characters." It's a big leap you've taken...

Riggan shifts nervously.

RIGGAN

Well... Absolutely. As you said... that Barthes said... Birdman, like Icarus...

CLARA

Hang on. Who's this Barthes guy? Which Birdman was he in?

GABRIEL

Roland Barthes was a French philosopher, who--

CLARA

Oh. Okay. Sure. Now, is it true
you've been injecting yourself with
semen from baby pigs?

RIGGAN

What?

CLARA

As a method of facial rejuvenation.

RIGGAN

Who told you that?

CLARA

It was tweeted by...
(checks her notes)

PROSTATEWHISPERS.

RIGGAN

It's a lie.

CLARA

I know. But did you do it?

RIGGAN

No!

GABRIEL

Are you afraid at all that people
will say you're doing this play to
battle the impression that you're a
washed-up super hero?

RIGGAN

No. I'm not. And that's exactly why
20 years ago I refused to do
Birdman 4.

HAN

Birdman 4??? You do Birdman 4???

Jake opens the door and the camera pans to him.

JAKE

Okay. That's enough for today.
Thank you for coming. We're
expecting some great pieces from
you...

Riggan stares at the Birdman poster.

JAKE (CONT'D)

Publicity guys are trying to get
you a Times feature.

Riggan stands up and pulls the Birdman poster off of the
wall.

JAKE (CONT'D)
So, How'd it-- Whoa. If I were you
I wouldn't do that.

RIGGAN
I don't want to look at it anymore.

JAKE
That was a present from the crew.
Don't fuck with those guys, they're
union.

RIGGAN
I don't care.

Riggan leaves the poster on the floor, facing the wall, and
walks to the window. He opens it. We can hear distant drums
coming from the street.

JAKE
So... How'd it go?

RIGGAN
Great.

JAKE
(Worried.)
Did they ask about Ralph?

RIGGAN
Nope.

JAKE
Good. He did it, you know? The
motherfucker threatened to sue us.
Didn't even wait to get out of the
hospital.

RIGGAN
And, what did you say?

JAKE
What'd I say? I said, "You
motherfucker. You're threatening
me? ME? I swear to god, you fuck, I
so much as get a letter from a
lawyer, the press'll get the
pictures we got off your computer."

RIGGAN
What pictures?

JAKE
The guy has a thing for nuns... in
diapers. What do you care? You
shouldn't have any knowledge about
it anyway. The important thing is
that I made him go away.

RIGGAN
Right. That's great.

JAKE
Yeah, it's fantastic. One problem.
We don't have an actor. And if we
cancel the first preview the press
will smell the blood. We can't
afford to lose any more money. At
all.

RIGGAN
What do you want me to do?

JAKE
We pay an understudy, let's use the
understudy.

RIGGAN
No.

JAKE
No? Riggan, listen to me. Our dream
actor is not going to knock on that
door and say: "Hey fellas, when do
we start?"

There is a knock at the door. Leslie peeks in.

LESLIE
Can I talk to you for a second?

RIGGAN
Yeah. What's up?

LESLIE
Did you find another actor?

RIGGAN
No.

LESLIE
Okay. Well... Mike's available.

RIGGAN
He is?

JAKE
Mike who?

RIGGAN
I thought he was doing--

LESLIE
He was. He quit. Or got fired.

JAKE
Mike who?

RIGGAN
Which one? Quit or fired?

LESLIE
With Mike it's usually both.

JAKE
Mike Fucking Who?

LESLIE
Shiner.

JAKE
Yes!

RIGGAN
Jake...

JAKE
Yes! How do you know Mike Shiner?

LESLIE
We share a vagina.

RIGGAN
You think he'd want to do it?

LESLIE
Yeah.

JAKE
How do you know?

LESLIE
Because he said he'd want to do it.

JAKE
Yes!

RIGGAN
Jake. Hang on a minute.

JAKE
(to Riggan)
Ask me if he sells tickets.

RIGGAN
Does he sell tickets?

JAKE
A shitload of tickets. Now ask me
if the critics like him?

RIGGAN
Do they like him?

JAKE
They want to spooge on him.

RIGGAN
(Indicating Lesley.)
Hey.

JAKE
Leslie...

LESLIE
Right on his face.

JAKE
Everything for a reason, right?

RIGGAN
You think he'll be able to come
tonight?

LESLIE
I can call him and find out.

Riggan gives Jake a look.

JAKE
I'll call his agent.

Jake charges out of the room. The camera follows him into...

6 INT. HALLWAY - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

6

...the hallway and as Jake makes a left turn, Annie enters
from the right.

JAKE

Annie, turn the work lights on and get me a fresh copy of the script. We're gonna have a "put in" tonight.

ANNIE

Who?

JAKE

You'll find out...

Jake disappears down the hall and we follow Annie through the theater and onto...

7 INT. STAGE - THEATER - EVENING

7

...the stage, where she turns some of the stage work lights on. We pan along the stage until we find Riggan, wearing the same clothes as before, scanning the empty auditorium.

MIKE (O.S.)

Intimidating. Isn't it?

Riggan sees Mike Shiner (39) coming down the aisle, slovenly dressed with mussed hair and intense eyes.

MIKE (CONT'D)

Do you have any idea who walked these boards before you?

(Beat.)

Geraldine Page, Marlon Brando, Helen Hayes, Jason Robards... And now you. Riggan Thomson.

Riggan, trying to hide the intimidation.

RIGGAN

Thanks for coming on such short notice, Mike. I appreciate it.

MIKE

Hey. This is what we do.

(Indicates a script.)

So, you wrote this adaptation?

RIGGAN

I did.

MIKE

And you're directing the adaptation and starring...

RIGGAN

I am.

MIKE
Ambitious.

RIGGAN
Thank you.

A sly smile from Mike. He leaps onto the stage.

MIKE
Why don't we do a bit of it?

RIGGAN
Hey, I wasn't expecting you to--

MIKE
First preview is tomorrow, right?

RIGGAN
Yeah, but you can go on with the script until you feel comfortable--

MIKE
Let's just do some of it.

Riggan tries to hide his excitement. He grabs the script from a nearby table and walks it over to Mike.

RIGGAN
Take a look at page twenty--

MIKE
Yeah. I don't need that.

RIGGAN
What?

MIKE
I don't need the script. Just give me a cue.

RIGGAN
What are you talking about?

MIKE
Feed me a line.

RIGGAN
I don't-- What?

MIKE
Feed. Me. A line.

Riggan drops the script and begins the scene.

RIGGAN

"I'm the wrong person to ask. I didn't know the man. I've only heard his name mentioned in passing. I wouldn't know. You'd have to know the particulars. But I think what you're saying is that love is absolute."

Mike stares at Riggan, hyper-focused.

MIKE

(Ruminating.)

Am I saying that love is absolute?

(He transforms.)

"Yeah. The kind of love I'm talking about is. The kind of love I'm talking about you-- "

(An intense pause.)

Well, you don't try to kill people.

Riggan is transfixed, and almost immediately intimidated.

RIGGAN

How do you know the lines?

MIKE

I have a thing, a whatever, a gift.

(A beat.)

Come on, I helped Lesley get off book. Hey, give me that cue again.

RIGGAN

"I'm the wrong person to ask. I didn't know the man. I've only heard his name mentioned in passing. I wouldn't know. You'd have to know the particulars. But I think what you're saying is--"

MIKE

Okay, can I-- Do you mind if I--

RIGGAN

No, go ahead.

MIKE

Follow me. He says, "I'm the wrong person to ask." What's his intention? Is he fed up with the topic? Deflecting? Guilt about his wife maybe? Then four sentences all say the same thing... "I didn't even know the man." "I've only heard his name mentioned in passing." "I wouldn't know." "You'd have to know the particulars." First of all, particulars? What are you, my grandmother? But the point is, YOU DON'T KNOW THE GUY, WE FUCKING GET IT. Make it one line. "I didn't even know the guy." Right?

RIGGAN

You pretty much know my lines too, huh?

MIKE

Can we-- Are we doing something here? Come on let's go. Cut it down, give it to me again.

RIGGAN

"I'm the wrong person to ask--"

MIKE

Oh, right, sorry, you see? "I'm the wrong person to ask?" That's another fuck you. "Don't put me on the spot. Don't make me self conscious about my marriage when my wife is sitting right here..." See? Give it to me. Give me a good fuck you Come on...

RIGGAN

Okay, let me--

MIKE

Come on. Give it to me right now. Fuck me. Right now. Right here. Let's do it.

RIGGAN

Okay, yeah...

MIKE

DO IT!

RIGGAN

(Jumps in w/out
thinking.)
"Hey. I'm the wrong person to ask,
okay? I didn't even know the guy.
So what's your point?"

MIKE
"What's my point?"

RIGGAN
"What's your point? What are you
saying? Spit it out. You're saying,
what? That love is an absolute?"

MIKE
(Exploding.)
"Yeah! Alright? The kind of love
I'm talking about is absolute. The
kind of love I'm talking about you-
-
(A painful memory.)
Well, you don't try to kill people.

Riggan stands silently, his heart pounding.

MIKE (CONT'D)
So what do you think, boss? Do I
have a job?

Riggan calls over to the wings.

RIGGAN
What do you think?

Mike turns to see Sam, who has been there for a bit.

SAM
Larry needs to see him for a
fitting.

MIKE
I'm gonna take that as a yes.
(Walking to Sam.)
And you are...?

RIGGAN
That's my daughter, Sam.

MIKE
Right. Yeah. I can see it around
the...
(A beat)
She doesn't look anything like you.
(To Sam.)

And your job is...?

RIGGAN
She's my assistant.

MIKE
Your assistant...
(To Sam.)
And can you speak?

SAM
Yup. I can even 'sit', 'stay' or
'roll over' if you have any treats.

RIGGAN
Welcome aboard, Mike.

MIKE
(Mock saluting.)
Thank you, Captain.

We follow Mike and Sam off as they...

8 INT. HALLWAY - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

8

...advance through the hallways.

MIKE
I'm Mike Shiner, by the way.

SAM
I know who you are.
(Reluctantly honest.)
I saw you in 'Hothouse' at the
Geffen. It was... great.

MIKE
That ass is great.

She turns her head toward him with a disgusted expression.

SAM
Dude. Seriously?

Moving by her, into a dressing room.

MIKE
This is the theatre, honey. Don't
be so self-conscious.

She follows him into the room where we see...

9 INT. COSTUME DEPARTMENT - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

9

...Larry stressing out while he works on a costume. He turns to see Mike standing there. Sam stands against the wall, focused on her cell phone.

LARRY

Oh, thank the Lord and pass the biscuits! I finally have an actor to dress. Hello, Mr. Shiner.

MIKE

How're you doing, Larry?

LARRY

Better, now that you're here. Take off your clothes.

Mike takes off his shirt and hands it to Sam. She doesn't budge, and it hits the floor. He begins to unbutton his pants...

MIKE

You gonna stand there?

SAM

(Glancing at her cell.)

This is the theatre, honey. Don't be so self-conscious.

Larry searches for a few costume pieces.

LARRY

Okay. I'm gonna have to start from scratch, with less than twenty-four hours... Let's see if these--

He turns to see a completely naked Mike.

LARRY (CONT'D)

Holy-- What is happening? Where are your underpants?

MIKE

At home, under the bed, I think.

Sam glances at Mike for a second, then returns to her phone. Larry begins to help Mike into some pants which, given the situation, is very awkward.

LARRY

Okay. Everything is too small.

SAM

Yeah, you're not kidding.

Lesley enters the room immediately coming face to face with a naked Mike. She doesn't notice Sam who is partially hidden by a clothes rack. She just goes about trying a costume shirt.

LESLEY

Oh, that's nice...

(To Larry.)

Forgive him, Larry. Mike's like my five year old son. Neither one of them has clean underwear...

LARRY

Or pubic hair, I imagine.

(Folding the pants.)

Okay, well, I can take out the suit but we're going to need some new pants and shirts.

(Looking back.)

And underwear...

Mike just stands there naked, staring at his penis in the mirror.

LESLEY

(To Larry.)

This is too small.

(To Mike.)

What the hell are you doing?

MIKE

Waiting for Larry to finish.

LARRY

I'm finished.

Larry disappears deeper into the costume room.

MIKE

Okay, well, then I'm just standing here with my balls out.

LESLEY

Get dressed. Riggan's daughter is hanging around, and I don't need her to walk in here and--

MIKE

Leslie...

LESLEY

No, Mike. You haven't seen her.
She's always hanging around, just--
I don't-- Watching everyone. It's
creepy. It's--

MIKE

Les...

LESLEY

I don't know if the drugs fried her
brain or what, but I don't need her
running to her father saying you
showed her your junk.

MIKE

Okay, then we should probably get
her out of here.

Lesley's expression goes blank.

LESLEY

Oh, God. Really?

MIKE

Hey, Sammy...

SAM

It's Sam.

LESLEY

Fuck.

Sam steps forward.

LESLEY (CONT'D)

(To Sam.)

I didn't mean--

SAM

(Totally relaxed.)

It's cool. He's a handful, huh?

They both look back at Mike.

LESLEY

Almost.

Sam smiles at her and exits. Lesley wheels on Mike.

LESLEY (CONT'D)

Jesus... How is it you always
manage to find a new way to
humiliate me?

MIKE

To be fair, you make it really easy.

LESLEY

What the hell was she doing here?

MIKE

She brought me.

LESLEY

And stayed???

MIKE

I know, right? She's a little--

LESLEY

Look at me, Mike. This is Broadway. I'm here. Finally. And I'm begging you, if you love me, please, do me a favor... don't fuck it up.

MIKE

(Gently.)

Come here.

Lesley moves toward Mike. He cups her face in his hands tenderly. They are face to face.

MIKE (CONT'D)

Play with my balls...

She twists his nipples hard and walks out.

MIKE (CONT'D)

I won't fuck it up... Probably!

Larry reappears holding some clothes. We follow him out...

10 INT. HALLWAY - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

10

...through the hallway. He walks by Jake and Riggan who are mid conversation. We stay with them.

RIGGAN (O.S.)

I don't care, sign it.

JAKE (O.S.)

Listen to me.

RIGGAN (O.S.)

No you listen to me--

JAKE (O.S.)
I can't afford to listen to you...

LARRY
I'm gonna need to go shopping
again.

JAKE
Fucking sew something, you old
fuck!

RIGGAN
I don't care. Give him what he
wants.

JAKE
His agent is asking for almost four
times what we were paying--

RIGGAN
Then go into the reserve.

JAKE
The reserve is gone. You spent it
on the fog. And those fake trees...

RIGGAN
It's a dream sequence, it--

JAKE
And three union midgets that dance
around like--

RIGGAN
You're not supposed to call them
midgets--

JAKE
The reserve is gone!

RIGGAN
Listen to me, you didn't see what I
just saw. But you will, at the
preview tomorrow. Look, get the
contract done. I'll get the money.

Riggan begins marching toward the stage.

JAKE
(Calling after him.)
When???

Laura comes down some stairs and chases Riggan.

LAURA
(Incredulous.)
Hey, is it true? Shiner?

RIGGAN
He's in.

LAURA
Holy shit! When can I meet him?

RIGGAN
He's in a fitting with Larry.

Lesley comes down the hallway.

LESLEY
I'm going to Starbucks. You guys
want anything?

RIGGAN
I'm fine. How's Mike?

LESLEY
Did you talk to your daughter?

RIGGAN
No.

LESLEY
He's great.

LAURA
(To Lesley. Matter-of-
factly.)
Honey, your tits look like fucking
anjou pears in that top!

LESLEY
(Uncomfortable.)
Okay, well I'm gonna-- Thank you.

She walks away.

LAURA
And that ass. Like two eggs in a
hanky!

Riggan walks, Laura follows him.

LAURA
Okay, I was going to tell you this
over dinner, but everything-- I
have some news too.

RIGGAN
Good or bad? Cause right now--

A technician walks by.

LAURA
(Whispering.)
I missed my last two periods.
(Beat.)
I think it's happening this time.

Riggan stops. Silent. A beat.

LAURA (CONT'D)
Is that good or bad?
(He stares at her.)
Riggan...?

RIGGAN
It's good. It's great.

She smiles, her eyes filled with emotion. Riggan smiles back, and nods absently.

LAURA
Say something else...

RIGGAN
(Joking.)
You're pretty sure it's mine?

LAURA
(Unamused but plays
along)
Well, let's see. There's you. Jake.
That masseuse wore a condom so...
Yes, it's yours... idiot.

She puts her head on Riggan's chest. We see his mind racing. Laura is moved, and confused.

LAURA (CONT'D)
Are you excited?

RIGGAN
Yeah.

LAURA
Me too.

Laura moves slightly away from him and suddenly slaps him across the face. Riggan looks at her, confused.

RIGGAN

What--?

LAURA
You're not funny.

She kisses him intensely on the lips and briefly places his hand on her belly, then moves it up to her breasts. After a moment, she backs away.

LAURA (CONT'D)
First preview tomorrow. Here we go!

Laura turns and walks away. Riggan continues down the corridor. He passes by a Security Guard in front of a small TV. The camera becomes Riggan's POV and advances until...

11 INT. BACKSTAGE - THEATER - EVENING

11

...we go through the stage door. We scan the backstage area to see the stagehands ready to do their jobs. We can feel the electricity of a first preview.

On stage part of the kitchen set from before is visible. Annie stands at her podium, calling the cues for the show.

ANNIE
(Into her headset.)
Cue 34 and 35. Go.

She turns and looks directly into the camera.

ANNIE (CONT'D)
Places.

RIGGAN (O.S.)
Okay.

Riggan walks on screen wearing his costume, carrying a bucket of ice and a bottle of gin. He goes to the opposite side of the stage and takes his place in the wings. He peeks out at the audience who seem to be watching with interest.

Then we pan to the stage to find Mike, Lesley and Laura performing the scene we saw at the beginning, around the table. Mike looks comfortable, sipping at his drink. A half empty bottle of gin on the table.

MIKE
The maniac shot himself right in front of us. I rode with him in the ambulance to the hospital.

LESLEY

I'll never get that image out of my head. Right before he did it, his eyes-- they were so sad... lonely.

LAURA

Did you have to treat him?

MIKE

I didn't have to. But I did.

(Pouring another drink.)

He was in bad shape. His head swelled up to like twice the size of a normal head. I'd never seen anything like it. And I swear to God, I hope I never do again.

Riggan stands near Annie.

RIGGAN

He's good.

ANNIE

He's incredible. I think he's drinking real gin.

Riggan looks out at Mike, who is refilling his glass.

RIGGAN

What?

A stagehand gives Riggan a bottle. Riggan watches and waits for his cue.

MIKE

Ask Nick what real love is. He'll agree with me. You watch.

LESLEY

Why don't we just head to the restaurant?

LAURA

Don't get him started, Mel. You haven't seen how he's been lately. He's been depressed. I'm worried about him. He's been--

She gently pushes Riggan and we follow him on stage...

...where Mike goes to refill his glass with the last of the real gin. Riggan snatches the bottle out of his hands and gulps the rest, straight from the bottle.

RIGGAN

Been what?

(Beat.)

I'll tell you what real love is.
This happened a few months ago.

(Drops bottle on table)

And it ought to make us ashamed
when we talk like we know what
we're talking about when we talk
about love.

LAURA

Nick, for God's sake. Are you
getting drunk?

RIGGAN

(Pointed at Mike.)

I don't have to be drunk to say
what I think.

MIKE

Nobody's drunk. We're just having a
few drinks.

LESLEY

You've had more than a few.

RIGGAN

What are you, counting?

LAURA

Don't you talk to her like that.
Don't talk like a drunk if you're
not--

RIGGAN

(Exploding.)

Shut up. For once in your life.
Will you do me a favor and shut up
for a minute?

(Beat.)

Like I was saying... There's this
old couple, had a car wreck out on
the interstate. Some drunk kid
plowed his dad's pick up into their
camper.

We begin to hear the underscoring of violins.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)

Fucking teenager. By the time I got to the hospital, the kid was dead. He was off in a corner laid out on a gurney. We took the old couple up to the O.R.. They were a mess. We worked like hell on them for most of the night...

Over the speech, Mike reaches for the new bottle that Riggan placed on stage. He refills his glass.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)

When we were done, we wrapped them in full body casts. The husband was depressed. Even when I told him his wife was gonna pull through, he was still depressed. So, I got up to his mouth hole and asked him, and he told me it was because he couldn't see her through the eye holes. Can you imagine? I'm telling you, the man's heart was breaking because he couldn't turn his goddamn head and see his goddamn wife.

Riggan is doing a good job. Lesley and Laura are genuinely moved. Mike notices. He sips his drink.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)

I mean... It was killing him. Killing him that he--

MIKE

I'm tired of this shit.

They all look at Mike. In silence.

MIKE (CONT'D)

(to Riggan)

What the fuck is this? Water?

He hurls the glass against the wall. Some laughter from the audience. Riggan stares at him, confused. He presses on.

RIGGAN

It was killing the old bastard...

MIKE

Did you just give me water?

RIGGAN

Come on, Mike.

MIKE

Come on what?

RIGGAN

Take it easy. You're drunk.

MIKE

Of course I'm drunk! I'm supposed to be drunk! This is Carver, man! The guy lost a piece of liver every time he wrote a page! If I'm supposed to drink gin then bring me fuckin gin! I mean, you fucked the time period! You took all the good lines for yourself! At least let me--

The audience is now hysterical. Dozens of cell phones pointing at the stage. Mike walks toward the apron, facing the audience.

MIKE (CONT'D)

Oh, okay. Seriously? You people are pathetic. Put the cell phones down and join the real world! Will somebody please just live in the real world?!!

He crosses to the refrigerator.

LAURA

Where's he going?

LESLEY

(Firmly.)

Mike, cut it out.

Mike rummages through the fridge.

MIKE

Look at this. It's all fake.

(Tossing items out of the fridge.)

The milk is fake. The butter is fake.

Riggan storms off the stage.

MIKE (CONT'D)

(To Riggan.)

Your performance is fake.

(He finds some fried chicken.)

Hey! There's chicken. Real chicken.
The only thing real up here is the
chicken. So I'm gonna stick with
the chicken.

The audience laughs harder.

MIKE (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Hey, this is good bird, man!

Riggan charges through the chaos backstage running into a
panicked Annie.

RIGGAN
Get Mike out of here.

ANNIE
How do you want me to do that?

Riggan keeps walking up to...

13 INT. HALLWAY - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

13

...the hallway. Jake chases him.

RIGGAN
I want him gone.

JAKE
No.

RIGGAN
What?

JAKE
We can't do that.

RIGGAN
What are you-- Of course we can do
that. It's our show.

JAKE
Riggan, listen to me--

Riggan comes to a halt and faces Jake.

RIGGAN
No. You listen to me. Get him the
fuck out of my play. Did you see
him out there?

JAKE

It was a preview! Nobody gives a shit about previews. Nothing matters until that old bat from the New York Times is sitting in that audience on opening night.

RIGGAN

We're getting rid of him. I'm not going to stand up on that stage and--

JAKE

Shut up! Just shut up for once and listen to me. As soon as we announced he was taking over, the advance doubled. We can't afford to lose a preview. We can't afford to lose money. We can't afford to lose Mike. This is about being respected, validated, remember? That's what you told me. That's how you got me into this shit. Now, you're the director. Get him under control.

(A beat. As a friend.)

These are not the nineties anymore.

Jake storms away. Riggan heads toward his dressing room. Out of nowhere, Mike barrels into him, pinning him against a wall.

RIGGAN

(Startled.)

Holy Fuck!

Mike presses up against Riggan, breathing down his neck. After a painful silence...

MIKE

(Like he's possessed.)

You were good...

RIGGAN

Meet me in front of the theater in 10 minutes.

Mike chuckles and slaps Riggan gently on the face before he disappears into his dressing room. Riggan begins walking again. We follow him into...

...his dressing room. He goes into the bathroom and quickly washes his face.

SYLVIA (O.S.)
What the hell was going on up
there?

We pan over to see his ex-wife Sylvia (43), standing in one corner, staring at Riggan. She is elegant and simply beautiful.

RIGGAN
I didn't know you were here
tonight.

SYLVIA
That guy's an asshole, huh?

Riggan dries his hands with a towel and comes out of the bathroom.

RIGGAN
What are you doing here?

SYLVIA
Sam and I are going to grab a bite
after she's finished with--

RIGGAN
No, I mean here Now.

SYLVIA
Well. I know how much this means to
you, so--

RIGGAN
I appreciate that.

A beat.

SYLVIA
So, how's it going?

RIGGAN
The play?

SYLVIA
No, you and Sam.

RIGGAN
It's good.
(A beat.)
It's the same.

SYLVIA
Do you talk to her?

RIGGAN
We talk. We-- I don't know, it's
been crazy around here.

SYLVIA
You understand where her head is at
right now.

RIGGAN
Of course.

SYLVIA
She's trying to stay away from
everything and everyone that got
her into rehab in the first place,
but...

RIGGAN
...I know, Sylvia...

SYLVIA
...But that's all she had. So
she's--

RIGGAN
I really do get it.

SYLVIA
I know you're caught up in all this
stuff, but--

RIGGAN
Stuff...

SYLVIA
You know what I mean.
(Beat.)
Riggan... You don't have to be a
great father right now, you just
have to be one.

RIGGAN
Yeah.

Suddenly, Laura opens the door and sticks her head in.

LAURA
(Noticing Sylvia.)
Oh, sorry.

She closes the door. Awkward silence.

SYLVIA
So how is that going? Is she and
Sam--?

RIGGAN
I don't wanna talk about it.

He goes to a small fridge, takes out a beer and closes it.

SYLVIA
You're drinking?

RIGGAN
I'm having a beer.

SYLVIA
Okay...

He sits and sips in silence for a moment. Then he begins to
take out the wig.

RIGGAN
So, what's going on with you?

SYLVIA
Me? Nothing. Everything's the same
I guess. I'm going back to
teaching.

RIGGAN
I'm thinking about refinancing the
Malibu house.

SYLVIA
Wh-- I'm sorry?

RIGGAN
I'm thinking about--

SYLVIA
No, I heard you. I just need a
second to--

(A beat.)
That's gonna be Sam's house. Why
would you--

(A beat.)
What? For this play?

RIGGAN
(Honest and vulnerable.)
I need the money.

SYLVIA

Do you have any idea how crazy that sounds?

RIGGAN

What do you want me to say? My health lasted longer than the money... Go figure that out.

Riggan seems pensive and lost.

SYLVIA

Riggan...

(Beat.)

What's going on?... Look at me.

Riggan gently looks up to Sylvia.

RIGGAN

I have a chance to do something right. And I have to take it. I have to.

SYLVIA

It's funny. I was sitting here waiting for you, and all of a sudden I couldn't remember why we broke up.

Silence. Then, as if he hasn't heard what she said.

RIGGAN

The last time I flew here from LA, George Clooney was sitting two seats in front of me. With those cuff links, and that... chin We ended up flying through this really bad storm. The plane started to rattle and shake, and everyone on board was crying... and praying And I just sat there-- Sat there thinking that when Sam opened that paper it was going to be Clooney's face on the front page. Not mine.

(A beat.)

Did you know that Farrah Fawcett died on the same day as Michael Jackson?

She smiles sadly. She kisses him on the head and goes to the door.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)

Why did we break up?

SYLVIA
 (Looks him in the eye.)
 You threw a kitchen knife at me...

Riggan is smacked by that memory. His eyes on the floor.

SYLVIA (CONT'D)
 ...and one hour later you were
 telling me how much you loved me.
 (Beat.)
 Just because I didn't like that
 ridiculous comedy you did with
 Goldie Hawn didn't mean I did not
 love you. But that's what you
 always do. You confuse love with
 admiration.

She smiles sadly. He looks at her. As Sylvia opens the door,
 she turns back to Riggan...

SYLVIA (CONT'D)
 It's your house, so do what you
 want with it. Just make sure you're
 there for our daughter.

RIGGAN
 I will.

SYLVIA
 You're not Farrah Fawcett, Riggan.

She exits. Painful silence... until...

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
 We should have done that reality
 show they offered us. "The
 Thomsons." That would've been good.
 Crazy, druggy, wise ass daughter.
 Milfy wife with the perky tits.
 People would have watched that.

RIGGAN
 (To the poster.)
 Shut up.

Riggan stands up and grabs his jacket. He opens the door and
 goes out to...

15 INT. HALLWAY - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

15

...the hallway.

BIRDMAN (V.O.)

Where are we goin'?

RIGGAN
(Almost whispering.)
Leave me alone.

Riggan walks between crew members. Annie interrupts him.

ANNIE
The sun bed is here.

RIGGAN
What does that mean?

ANNIE
It means there's a sun bed out
there being delivered to in here

RIGGAN
Who ordered a sun bed?

ANNIE
Mike. He says it's for his
character. Carver's red necks,
"people of the land". Part of his
process and that shit.

Riggan cannot deal with this right now. He continues walking
until he arrives at a metal door that takes him out to...

16 EXT. AN ALLEY WAY - OUTSIDE THE THEATER - CONTINUOUS

16

...an alley way. Riggan walks toward the street. There is a
man playing drums. Riggan finds Mike leaning against a parked
car, dazed and looking up at the marquis...

RIGGAN
Let's go. Walk.

Riggan begins to walk, Mike follows.

MIKE
Where are we going?

RIGGAN
To get you some coffee. Have I done
anything to disrespect you?

MIKE
Not yet.

RIGGAN
I have a lot riding on this play.

MIKE
Is that right?

RIGGAN
People know who I am, and--

MIKE
Bullshit.

RIGGAN
Mike--

MIKE
Bullshit. People don't know you.
They know the guy in the bird suit.
They know the guy who tells those
quaint, slightly vomituous stories
on Letterman.

RIGGAN
Well, I'm sorry for being popular,
but that--

MIKE
(With irony.)
Popular? POPULAR?... Oh God,
popularity is just the slutty
little cousin of prestige.

RIGGAN
Okay, I don't even know what that--

MIKE
My reputation is riding on this
play. And that's... That is...

RIGGAN
A lot?

MIKE

A lot. Exactly. Fuck you. Yes. This doesn't work out for you, you get to go home to your studio pals and jump right back into that cultural genocide you guys are perpetrating. "There's a douchbag born every minute". That was P.T. Barnum's premise when he got rich inventing the circus. And you and your pals know nothing's changed, and whatever toxic shit you make people are still gonna pay to see it. But, after you're gone, I'll still be here. I'll still be making my living on the stage. Baring my soul. Wrestling with emotions, complex emotions.

RIGGAN

Right. Is that what tonight was about then?

(Mocking him.)

Wrestling with "complex emotions"?

MIKE

Tonight was about making it alive. About making it bleed This isn't the Warner Brothers lot, Riggan. This is the city, and this is how we do things.

Mike turns and opens the front door of The Rum House.

RIGGAN

Where are you going?

MIKE

They have coffee in here.

He walks into the restaurant. Riggan backtracks and we follow him into...

17 INT. RUM HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

17

...The Rum House. Mike stands at the bar, the bartender already pouring two whiskeys.

MIKE

(To bartender.)

Thanks, Tommy.

Tommy nods and walks away.

RIGGAN
(Getting back on point.)
People were laughing in our faces.

MIKE
(Handing Riggan a drink.)
Tonight they were laughing,
tomorrow they'll be... be..
tweeting about us. Fuck 'em. Who
cares??? These are the people who
pay half price to watch us
rehearse. Stop fucking caring!

RIGGAN
We're doing Raymond Carver. This
play is a drama. This play is--

MIKE
You don't know what this play is.
These are previews. This is where
we find out what the play is.

Mike points to an Older Woman sitting at the bar. She sips a
martini and scribbles in a notebook with a sour expression.

MIKE (CONT'D)
You see that woman over there? The
one that looks like she just licked
a homeless guy's ass? Nothing
matters until she writes five
hundred words about us in the New
York Times.

RIGGAN
That's...

MIKE
Tabitha Dickinson. Yes. And,
believe it or not, the only thing
that matters in theater is whether
she likes us or not. She does, we
run. She doesn't, we're fucked.

RIGGAN
(Preoccupied.)
She does look like she licked a
homeless guy's ass.

MIKE

Do me a favor, don't get your
panties in a twist over a preview,
alright? And don't tell me how to
do my job. Cause, this is my town.
And, to be honest, nobody gives a
shit about you around here.

LADY (O.S.)
You're Riggan Thompson, right?

Two fat tourists in "Mamma Mia" t-shirts, with a seven year
old kid, approach the table.

HUSBAND
(Timidly.)
We're sorry to interrupt...

LADY
Would you mind terribly if we got a
picture?

RIGGAN
Of course. It's no trouble at all.

The Lady shoves her camera into Mike's hands.

LADY
(To Mike.)
Would you mind?

Mike gets up with a blank expression and takes the camera.
The Lady pushes the kid into the booth next to Riggan.

LADY (CONT'D)
(Ordering Mike.)
The button right on top there.

KID
Who is this guy?

LADY
(To his son.)
Come on, Billy. He used to be like
Batman.

She yanks the kid closer and they squeeze up against Riggan.
Mike takes the photo and holds the camera to the lady.

LADY (CONT'D)
(To Mike)
I think you screwed that one up.
Take another one.

Mike takes another picture.

LADY (CONT'D)
 (To Riggan.)
 God bless you, darlin'. You're very
 sweet. And handsome!

She kisses Riggan hard on the mouth. Then gets up, giddy, and takes her son by the hand. As the couple leaves, husband shoves a five dollar bill into Mike's hands.

HUSBAND
 We really appreciate it.

An agitated Mike takes a sip of whiskey.

MIKE
 Are we good here? Cause I'm gonna go.

RIGGAN
 See you tomorrow.

Mike places the dollar under one of the shot glasses and begins to walk away, but then stops and turns curiously.

MIKE
 Why Raymond Carver? You never told me.

Riggan looks at Mike for a second, than reaches for his wallet and produces an old cocktail napkin with some writing on it. He slides it to Mike.

RIGGAN
 A long time ago, I did a play back in high school in Michigan. He was in the audience. He sent this backstage after.

MIKE
 "Thank you for an honest performance. Ray Carver." What is this?

Riggan looks vulnerable. He is trying to make Mike understand the importance of the napkin, to build a bridge between them.

RIGGAN
 And that's when I knew I was going to be an actor.

Mike can't stop himself from smiling.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)
 Why is that funny?

MIKE
He wrote it on a cocktail napkin.

RIGGAN
So...

Mike slides the napkin back to Riggan.

MIKE
He was drunk.

He walks away and we follow him as he passes by the bar next to Tabitha Dickinson, the Critic.

TABITHA
You headed to Hollywood, Mike?

Mike stops.

MIKE
Hollywood's headed here, Tabby.

TABITHA
(A devilish smile.)
Good luck with that.

Mike looks directly into her eyes.

MIKE
"A man becomes a critic when he can not be an artist, in the same way that a man becomes an informer when he cannot be a soldier." Flaubert, right?

He flashes his own devilish smile. She stares back. If she weren't so much older than him, you'd swear there was sexual electricity between them.

TABITHA
He's a Hollywood clown in a Lycra bird suit.

MIKE
Yeah. And at 8 o'clock tomorrow, he's gonna get on stage and risk everything. What're you gonna be doing?

A standoff.

TABITHA
Don't you ever worry that I'll give you a bad review?

MIKE

Oh, I'm sure you will. If I ever
give a bad performance.

(Beat.)

Ms. Dickinson.

TABITHA

Mr. Shiner.

Mike smiles and waves over to an obviously nervous Riggan. He goes toward the exit, but we stay with Tabitha, scribbling on her notebook. Suddenly she raises her eyes and, with a dark expression, looks at Riggan who is passing by.

We follow Riggan toward the exit. Through the window we see him leave the restaurant. Then we pan to a wooden wall, and this wall takes us to...

18 INT. HALLWAY - THEATER - LATER

18

...the theater hallway. Riggan walks through the quiet corridor, until he arrives at...

19 INT. GREEN ROOM - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

19

...the Green Room. Sam sits listlessly, drawing some lines across a roll of toilet paper.

RIGGAN

What're you still doing here?

SAM

(Continues scribbling.)

Nothing. I'm-- Nothing. Your
costumes are hanging in your room.

RIGGAN

Great...

SAM

I got the coconut water you wanted.
If you want me to get--

RIGGAN

Hey.

SAM

What?

RIGGAN

I'm not sure if I said thank you.

SAM
For what?

RIGGAN
All of it. You've been doing a good
job. And I've been...

SAM
Yeah.

RIGGAN
So, I just wanted to say that--
(He stops abruptly.)
What is that?

SAM
What...?

RIGGAN
That smell.

SAM
I don't--

RIGGAN
Look at me.

SAM
What are you--

RIGGAN
Look at me.

She does. He examines her eyes, then immediately rises,
scouring the room.

SAM
Dad...

RIGGAN
(Continuing to search.)
You have to be shitting me... Where
is it?

SAM
Could we not do this?

Riggan pulls a jar of peanut butter from the trash.

RIGGAN
What is this?

SAM

That is chunky peanut butter that happens, by the way, to have Omega-

Riggan pulls a stubbed joint out of the jar.

RIGGAN
This.

SAM
Oh. That's pot.

RIGGAN
Sam.

SAM
Alright, just relax.

RIGGAN
Relax? What the hell are you doing?

SAM
Protecting myself from cataracts?

RIGGAN
You can't do this to me!

SAM
To you ?

RIGGAN
SHUT UP! You know what I'm talking about.

SAM
Yeah. You're talking about you What else is new?

RIGGAN
Don't try to--

SAM
What? Make it about me? I wouldn't dream of it.

RIGGAN
Listen to me. I'm trying to do something that's important...

SAM
This is not important.

RIGGAN

It's important to me! Alright?
 Maybe not to you, or your cynical
 playmates whose sole ambition is to
 end up going viral and who, by the
 way, will only be remembered as the
 generation that finally stopped
 talking to one another. But to
 me... To me... This is-- God. This
 is my career, this is my chance

to do some work that actually means something.

SAM

Means something to who? You had a
 career before the third comic book
 movie, before people began to
 forget who was inside the bird
 costume. You're doing a play based
 on a book that was written 60 years
 ago, for a thousand rich, old white
 people whose only real concern is
 gonna be where they go to have
 their cake and coffee when it's
 over. Nobody gives a shit but you.
 And let's face it, Dad, it's not
 for the sake of art. It's because
 you just want to feel relevant
 again. Well, there's a whole world
 out there where people fight to be
 relevant every day. And you act
 like it doesn't even exist! Things
 are happening in a place that you
 willfully ignore, a place that has
 already forgotten you. I mean who
 are you? You hate bloggers. You
 make fun of twitter. You don't even
 have a Facebook page. You're the
 one who doesn't exist. You're doing
 this because you're scared to
 death, like the rest of us, that
 you don't matter. And you know
 what? You're right. You don't. It's
 not important. You're not
 important. Get used to it.

Silence. Riggan seems devastated, and Sam can see that.

SAM

Dad...

She looks at him sympathetically, but not knowing what to
 say... exits.

After a moment Riggan gets up and heads for the trash can. He digs out the roach, grabs some matches and lights it. Music begins to sound. He inhales deeply and holds the smoke for a few seconds and finally exhales. He coughs, tosses away the joint and heads out of the kitchen. We follow him...

20 INT. HALLWAY - THEATRE - CONTINUOUS

20

...as he slowly walks until he disappears into the darkness of the corridor. We keep moving forward until we end up...

21 INT. BACKSTAGE - THEATRE - EVENING

21

...backstage. We are in the middle of the second preview. The music continues, it belongs to the play.

Laura is by herself on stage performing the end of a scene. She stands in the middle of a surrealistic forest set, at dusk. There is fog, and trees. A strong, artificial wind blows through Laura's hair. Desolate music.

LAURA

(To the audience as
soliloquy.)

In the days before Nick's
depression really started to eat
away at him, he had no idea I was
pregnant. And I never intended on
telling him. I guess we make
choices in life, and we choose to
live with them. Or not. I didn't
want that baby...

Three dancers on stage pass by in front of Laura. We follow the dancers backstage where we find Mike and Lesley wearing pajamas.

LAURA (O.S.) (CONT'D)

...Not because I didn't love Nick.
And not because I didn't love the--
The idea of it. But because I just
wasn't ready to love myself.
There's a certain distance to it
all now. A wistful distance.
Underscored by a gentle breeze and
the sound of the birds... laughing
at the whimsy of it all.

A stage hand helps Mike and Lesley into a double bed. The camera slips under the covers with them and stays there.

MIKE

(Whispering.)
Hey, Les...

LESLEY
(Whispering.)
What?

MIKE
I'm hard.

LESLEY
No, you're not. It's just that
sometimes you don't consider other
people's feelings.

MIKE
No. I'm hard Feel.

LESLEY
Oh, you gotta be kidding.

The stage begins to revolve as we hear...

22 INT. STAGE - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

22

...music through the transition. It remains dark.

MIKE
Let's really do this. Let's fuck.

LESLEY
Are you crazy? No.

Mike rolls on top of Lesley.

LESLEY (CONT'D)
Cut it out...

Mike continues to maneuver himself.

LESLEY (CONT'D)
I'm serious, Mike. Stop!

MIKE
I'm Mel. Not Mike. Mel.

A knock on a door.

RIGGAN (O.S.)
Terri! Terri!

A furious Lesley tries to reposition herself under Mike.

RIGGAN (O.S.) (CONT'D)
 Terri! I know you're in there!

The knocking gets louder.

RIGGAN (O.S.) (CONT'D)
 Terri???

Mike, lost in his libido, has begun to have sex with Lesley. The camera comes out from under the covers and pans to Riggan who stumbles into what is now the Motel Room set. He wears a mustache and a long wig, that makes him look like a wild man. He holds a gun in his right hand. A neon "Motel" sign is illuminated. A clever effect of falling rain is visible behind the set, accompanied by the appropriate sound effect. Riggan is wet because of the "rain".

Lesley uses Riggan's entrance to escape from Mike.

LESLEY
 Ed!

Mike hops out of bed, unaware of the very noticeable erection protruding underneath his pajama bottoms.

Some laughter from the audience.

LESLEY (CONT'D)
 What are you doing here?

Lesley doesn't understand the audience response, until she notices the erection herself.

RIGGAN
 (To Lesley.)
 Why? I need you to tell me why. I
 lived for you. I worshipped you...

MIKE
 Listen Ed, I know this is hard but-
 -

More laughter. Riggan is disturbed, but he continues...

RIGGAN
 (to Mike)
 Fuck you. Shut up. Fuck you.

He shoves Mike violently to the floor.

LESLEY
 Eddie! Please!

Riggan points the gun at Mike's head.

RIGGAN

What's wrong with me? Why do I end up having to beg people to love me?

LESLEY

Ed. Eddie. Please... Give me the gun.

She begins to cry. Her performance is beautiful.

LESLEY (CONT'D)

Just look at me. I was drowning. I was not capable of-- You deserve to be loved. You do.

RIGGAN

I just wanted to be what you wanted.

(Beat.)

Now I spend every fucking minute praying to be someone else. Someone I'm not. Anyone...

MIKE

Put down the gun, Ed. She just doesn't love you anymore.

The audience is silent.

RIGGAN

(A sad smile.)

You don't, do you?

LESLEY

(With sympathy.)

No...

RIGGAN

And you never will...

LESLEY

I'm sorry.

RIGGAN

(A revelation.)

I don't exist. I'm not even here. I don't exist. None of this matters.

Riggan points the gun at Lesley. Then at Mike. Finally, he puts the gun to his own head and pulls the trigger. PUM! And with the explosion, a fake blood mechanism splatters brains onto the stage. Riggan drops to the floor.

A blackout. The audience applauds politely. The curtain falls. We follow Riggan off stage and into...

23 INT. BACKSTAGE - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

23

...the wings, where Annie immediately helps him remove the bloody and wet wig with the propeller mechanism. Laura waits next to them for their bows. Meanwhile, a stage hand crosses behind them, and we follow him as he goes on stage to...

24 INT. STAGE - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

24

...reposition some scenery for the curtain call. The camera carries us to the other side of the stage, where Mike and Lesley are in a heated exchange...

MIKE

Just, keep your voice down...

LESLEY

(Furious.)

You have to be shitting me. You can't get it up in six months...

(She starts hitting him.)..and now you try to fuck me in front of eight hundred strangers???

MIKE

What do you want from me? I have to feel it You know that. I told you that from the--

LESLEY

Oh, fuck you..

Music begins and the curtain rises. The audience applauds as Lesley and Mike stride onto the stage and take their bows, smiles plastered on their faces.

MIKE

...I was in the moment...

LESLEY

I told you to stop. You fucking animal

MIKE

But... You were incredible.

LESLEY

What is wrong with you?

Lesley starts back for the wings, and Mike follows her. In the background we see Riggan and Laura enter from the other side to take their bows.

MIKE

Listen I'm sorry, alright, I--

LESLEY

I want your shit out of the apartment.

They go back on stage and join Riggan and Laura for the company bow.

MIKE

Can we--

LESLEY

No we can't. Maybe up here you're Mr. Truth, Mike. But in the real world, where it counts, you're a fraud. How's that for truth? You... dick

Lesley storms off, leaving Mike and a confused Riggan on stage. Laura chases her off and straight into...

25 INT. HALLWAY - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

25

...the hallway.

LAURA

What's going on?

LESLEY

He's an asshole.

LAURA

What did he do now?

LESLEY

Oh, nothing. He just tried to fuck me in front of a full house.

LAURA

Oh, my God...

LESLEY

Right?

LAURA

That's kind of hot.

She follows Lesley into...

26 INT. LESLEY AND LAURA'S DRESSING ROOM - THEATER - CONTINUOUS 26

...the dressing room and closes the door. Lesley proceeds to smash everything on her dressing table. Then she looks in the mirror holding a hairbrush.

LESLEY

Why don't I have any self-respect?

LAURA

You're an actress, honey.

Lesley begins to cry. Laura hugs her.

LESLEY

I'm pathetic. You know, I've dreamt of being a Broadway actress since I was a little kid. And now I'm here. And I'm not a Broadway actress. I'm still just a little kid. And I keep waiting for someone to tell me I made it.

LAURA

(Hiding how moved she is.)

Hey. You made it.

LESLEY

I did?

LAURA

Sadly, it was with Mike Shiner, on a fake motel bed, in front of--

LESLEY

(A little laugh.)

Shut. Up.

Riggan steps into the doorway and sees Laura hugging Lesley.

RIGGAN

Is she okay?

LAURA

She's gonna be fine.

Riggan enters gingerly and walks up to Lesley.

RIGGAN

None of this is your fault.

(Into her eyes.)
You're beautiful. And talented. And
I'm lucky to have you. Okay?

LESLEY
Okay.

RIGGAN
Okay.

Riggan leaves the room. Laura leans on the makeup table.

LESLEY
That was very sweet.

LAURA
Yeah.

Laura is suddenly teary.

LESLEY
What's wrong?

A beat.

LAURA
(Smiling.)
Nothing. Two years, he's never said
anything like that to me.

LESLEY
(Into her eyes.)
Hey. You're smart. And beautiful.
And talented. And I'm lucky to have
you. Okay?

LAURA
We're gross.

LESLEY
We are.

Laura smiles and caresses Lesley's hand. They look at each other. Then Laura leans forward, close to Lesley's face...

LESLEY (CONT'D)
(Nervous.)
What are you doing?

LAURA
Nothing.

Laura kisses Lesley tenderly on the lips. Lesley seems confused. A few seconds of silence. Then...

LESLEY
Do it again.

Laura kisses her again. A knock at the door. They separate.
Mike opens the door holding the prop gun.

MIKE
(To Lesley.)
Can we talk about this like two--

Lesley hurls the hair brush at his head.

LESLEY
FUCK YOU!!!

MIKE
Okay, well, you're not ready.

Mike points the prop gun at her, pretends to fire and...

MIKE (CONT'D)
That was hot.

He exits the room. We follow him...

27 INT. HALLWAY - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

27

...down the hallway up to Riggan's dressing room. Riggan sits
at his table, picking the brains out of his hair.

MIKE
(Holding the gun.)
Your gun is ridiculous. It looks
like a plastic toy. And it still
has the red plug in the barrel.
(Shows the plug.)
You look like a seven year old when
you're holding it. I'm not
threatened by it at all.

He tosses the gun onto Riggan's table.

MIKE (CONT'D)
Have some self respect and get a
new one.
(Takes a step then
turns.)
That was a fun crowd, huh?

We follow Mike to...

28 INT. STAIRS - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

28

...the stairs. He climbs them as he lights a cigarette. He goes through a metal door that takes him out onto...

29 EXT. ROOFTOP - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

29

...a rooftop. The Marquis' of the other theaters glowing with the street lamps, a classic Broadway view.

Mike is surprised to find Sam sitting on the cornice of the building, a good fifty feet above 45th street. He goes next to her, looking down at the street.

MIKE

I don't think it's high enough.

Sam turns to him, uncomfortable by his presence.

SAM

Me neither.

MIKE

So, what are you doing up here?

SAM

(Hesitant.)

Adrenaline. Just came out of rehab.
Closest I get to a drug.

MIKE

You were in rehab?

SAM

(Distant.)

Yeah.

MIKE

Cool.

SAM

It wasn't all Dr. Drew or anything,
but that dude from American Pie was
there.

A VOICE

(From the street below.)

Juuump!

SAM

(Calling down.)

Eat me!

A VOICE

Okay. Jump on my face!

SAM
(To Mike.)
I love this city.

MIKE
Yeah.

SAM
(Casually.)
Why do you act like a dick all the time? Do you just do it to antagonize people?

MIKE
Maybe...

Sam turns and faces Mike.

SAM
You really don't give a shit if people like you or not...

MIKE
Not really.

SAM
(More comfortable.)
God, that's cool.

MIKE
Is it...?

Mike leans on the railing, looking down at the street. For a moment, he is somewhere else...

SAM
Hey.
(Mike doesn't respond.
She pushes him.)
Hey...

MIKE
What?

SAM
Let's play a game.

MIKE
A game?

SAM
Yeah.

MIKE

What are you, eight ?

SAM

What are you, seventy-eight? Truth or dare...?

MIKE

You gotta be--

SAM

Truth or dare?

He looks at her, intrigued.

MIKE

Truth.

SAM

The first time we met, you made a comment about my ass. Why'd you do it?

MIKE

Because you have a great ass, and I noticed it. So, I said it.

(A beat.)

Truth or dare?

SAM

Dare.

MIKE

Really...

SAM

Uh-huh.

A moment of tension.

MIKE

(Looking at the street.)

There's a bald guy about to walk by down there. Spit on his head.

SAM

No!

MIKE

You said dare.

SAM

Truth.

MIKE

Too late.

She stares into Mike's eyes, knowing she's being tested. She leans over the railing and spits down toward the street.

SAM

Happy?

MAN (O.C.)

(From the street)

Fuck you !

Sam laughs. Mike smiles at her carefree laugh. It could be the first time we've seen a genuine smile from him.

SAM

Truth or dare?

MIKE

Truth.

SAM

You're boring.

MIKE

Truth.

She stares him down.

SAM

(Nervous, pretending.)

Do you want to fool around with me?

A pause.

MIKE

No.

SAM

(Taken aback.)

Really? Why not?

MIKE

That's a second question.

SAM

It's a second part.

A pause.

MIKE

I'd be afraid I couldn't get it up.

Impressed with his honesty.

SAM
That didn't seem to be a problem
for you on stage.

MIKE
Nothing's a problem for me on
stage.

SAM
I wanna ask another question...

MIKE
You just asked--

SAM
One more.

MIKE
Go 'head.

SAM
If you weren't afraid. What would
you want to do to me?

He carefully considers it, then moves his face close to hers.

MIKE
I would want to pull the eyes out
of your head...

SAM
...That's sweet...

MIKE
...And stick them in my skull, and
then look out at this street and
see it the way I saw it when I was
your age.

Mike turns and stares out at the street once more. Sam stares
at the mystery that is Mike.

SAM
G'night, Mike.

She walks away and into the building, never looking back.

Mike stares out into the night. We move to his POV. The
street. Night turns to day. Pedestrians begin to walk below.

We crawl down the wall until we arrive at Riggan's dressing
room window. We push in to find...

30 INT. RIGGAN'S DRESSING ROOM - THEATER - DAY

30

...Riggan sitting with his feet on the window frame, staring at a manila envelope in his hands that reads... "R, MALIBU REFINANCE DOCS. SIGN AND SEND ASAP. J." Riggan sighs and props the letter up against the mirror.

With a soft knock, Laura enters. She stands in the doorway with an odd expression on her face.

RIGGAN

What now?

Laura lays the Arts section of the New York Times down in front of Riggan.

LAURA

Don't kill the messenger.

Riggan picks up the paper. His expression immediately changes. Laura watches him sympathetically.

LAURA (CONT'D)

He's an asshole.

Now we see the cover of the Arts section. There is a picture of Mike lounging on a black sofa, his bare feet on a table as he sips a glass of wine. The Title of the article reads... "CARVING OUT HIS PLACE IN THEATER HISTORY. Shiner says Raymond Carver is the reason he became an actor." Riggan involuntarily squeezes the paper as he reads on, filling with rage.

BIRDMAN (V.O.)

He's fooling you.

RIGGAN

Shut up.

LAURA

(Confused.)

I didn't say anything.

RIGGAN

Fuck. This is it?

(He passes a few pages.)

This can't be it.

LAURA

Page twelve.

Riggan searches desperately for page twelve. When he gets there, he finds a huge ad of the new Toyota Camry that almost fills the entire page, and down in the left corner a tiny press release with the title:

"From Birdman to Carver: An aging Action Hero Grasps for His Youth."

RIGGAN

(Reading.)

"Riggan Thompson, better known as the face of the Birdman films, tries not to lay an egg on Broadway..."

(Flipping pages.)

Where's the rest of it?

LAURA

There is no rest of it.

RIGGAN

They didn't use the photo I sent them.

LAURA

What photo?

RIGGAN

The one you liked. The one you said I look like a young Jack Nicholson.

LAURA

(She lights a candle.)

Don't worry about it. Someone'll be using that to pick up dog shit tomorrow.

RIGGAN

How can you be so calm about this?

LAURA

What are my other choices?

RIGGAN

Aren't you scared at all?

LAURA

About what?

RIGGAN

About being humiliated out there.

LAURA

It won't be the first time I've
been humiliated.

RIGGAN
I bet it won't.

Laura looks at him with fire in her eyes.

LAURA
You're an asshole.

She charges to the door and is about to leave when she turns
back to Riggan...

LAURA (CONT'D)
By the way... I'm not pregnant. So
there's one thing you don't have to
worry about.

She leaves, slamming the door behind her.

Riggan remains still. Mike seems to be smirking at him right
through the cover of the Arts section...

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
That pretentious, little, theater
fuck is stealing your thunder.

Riggan charges out of the room and into...

31 INT. HALLWAY - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

31

...the hallway. He walks to Mike's dressing room, finds the
door half opened and enters...

32 INT. MIKE'S DRESSING ROOM - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

32

...discovering Mike lying in a sun bed. His arm is sticking
out of it, holding on to a copy of Borges's 'Labyrinths'.

Riggan yanks the sun bed open. Mike is asleep, wearing tiny
sun goggles. Riggan slams the lid down on him.

MIKE
What the fuck is going on!

RIGGAN
Get up!

MIKE
Back away.

RIGGAN

Get up.

Riggan slaps Mike on the arm.

MIKE

Ow, fuck that hurts!

RIGGAN

So, Carver is the reason you became an actor?

MIKE

What?

RIGGAN

This is my play! I did the work. I raised the money. I arrange the press.

MIKE

They called me for an interview. I said-- I don't know, I said the first thing that came to mind. Jesus, we got the cover of the Arts section!

RIGGAN

You said the first-- Fuck the Arts section. The first thing that came to mind? Right. Cause that's you. Mr. Natural. Mr. Fuck the scene, just stare at my massive hard-on. Because that's the truth of the moment.

MIKE

You think it looked massive?

RIGGAN

Shut up. Shut the fuck up. You don't get hard on my stage unless I tell you to.

MIKE

Your stage? This stage belonged to a lot of great actor's, pal. But you are not one of them.

Mike storms out of the room. Riggan follows him into...

...the hallway. He slaps Mike on his sun burned back.

RIGGAN
So, you wrote your own lines?

He slaps him again.

MIKE
Ow. Fuck. Yes I did.

RIGGAN
You changed a few words, and
mumbled a little, you self absorbed
prick.

MIKE
Look who's talking...

RIGGAN
Let me tell you something, you
spiteful nobody piece of shit.

MIKE
Nobody? My hard-on has already
fifty thousand views on youtube.

RIGGAN
Fifty thousand views? A cat playing
with a dildo has more than that.

MIKE
I don't care.

RIGGAN
Yes you do.
(Beat.)
Everybody says: "Mike is so
honest".
(Smacks him.)
"So truthful".
(Smacks him again.)

MIKE
(Like a child.)
Ouch. Fuuuuuck. Cut the shit!

Riggan corners Mike against the wall.

RIGGAN
You said in the interview that your
father was a drunk, like Carver. Is
that true Mike? Is it really true?

Riggan stares intensely into Mike's eyes. Mike looks away.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)
 Because my father was. My father
 was a mean fucking drunk. Beat the
 shit out of us. But we were okay
 with the beatings. You know why?
 Because at least when he was
 beating us, he wasn't thinking
 about taking us out to his tool
 shed...

Mike's expression changes.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)
 That sonofabitch would smile and
 say, "Do you want to kneel down and
 unbuckle my belt? Or do you want me
 to take it off and use it?" I
 learned how to make myself numb.
 But my sister--
 (Holding back tears.)
 My little sister...

Riggan can't go on. Mike is horrified.

MIKE
 Jesus, Riggan. I'm really sorry. I
 didn't-- That's fucking horrible...

RIGGAN
 (Crazy smile.)
 Yeah. It's also not true. See?
 (Cracking up.)
 I can pretend too, you little dick!

Riggan shoves Mike violently.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)
 Don't fuck with me, Mike.

MIKE
 You're crazy...

RIGGAN
 You have no idea what I'm capable
 of. You understand me?

Riggan pulls the paper out of his back pocket.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)
 Working with Riggan Thomson is like
 waltzing with a monkey?

He smacks Mike in the head with the paper and begins to jump
 in front of him, ready to fight.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)
Let's go. Put your hands up.

MIKE
(Tauntingly.)
Don't you want to go put on your
tights and your--

Riggan punches him on the face. Mike needs a few seconds to understand what has just happened. Then they begin to wrestle in the hallway. Mike breaks free from the headlock.

MIKE (CONT'D)
What are you gonna do? You gonna
get rid of me? Huh? What do you
think my friend Tabitha is going to
write in the Times after you get
rid of me?

Riggan stares at Mike, paralyzed by the truth. Finally, he turns and marches to his dressing room, and we follow him...

34 INT. RIGGAN'S DRESSING ROOM - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

34

...Riggan slams the door shut and paces in a rage. He glares at a make-up box on the table and, points his finger at it, and sends it flying across the room.

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
You are lame, Riggan. Rolling
around with that third rate actor
in an 800 seat shithole like this.

RIGGAN
(Whispering.)
Breathing in, I feel my rage.
Breathing out, I embrace my mental
formations.

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
You're going to let that poncey
theater fuck threaten you?

Riggan continues breathing deeply with his eyes tightly closed. He smiles a tiny artificial smile.

RIGGAN
(Whispering.)
Breathing in, I am calm. Breathing
out, I ignore my mental formations.
This is a mental formation. This is
a mental form--

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
 Stop that shit. I am not a mental
 formation. I am "you", asshole.

Riggan looks down at the poster on the floor.

RIGGAN
 (Whispering.)
 Leave me alone.

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
 You were a movie star, remember?
 Pretentious, but happy...

Riggan opens his eyes, slowly. A sad expression on his face.

RIGGAN
 I was not happy.

BIRDMAN
 ...Ignorant but charming. Now you
 are a tiny bitter cocksucker.

RIGGAN
 Shut up! Stop whining! I was
 miserable!

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
 Yeah. But fake miserable. Hollywood
 miserable.

Riggan points his fingers at a lamp and sends it flying.

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
 What are you trying to prove? Huh?
 That you're an artist? You're not.

RIGGAN
 Fuck you!

Riggan points his fingers at a chair and sends it flying.

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
 Fuck you , coward! And fuck those
 critics that made you quit. Our
 franchise grossed billions worldwi-

-

RIGGAN
 And billions of flies eat shit
 everyday! So what? Does that make
 it good?
 (Beat.)

And I don't know if you've noticed,
 but that was 1992! Look at me!
 (He takes off his shirt.)
 This is what's left!
 (Grabbing his neck.)
 This!
 (Grabbing his chest.)
 This!
 (Totally exploding.)
 I'm fucking disappearing! I'm the
 answer to a fucking trivial pursuit
 question.

Riggan sits down, exhausted.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)
 What part of that don't you get?
 You're fucking dead.

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
 We are not dead. We're--

RIGGAN
 Stop saying 'we'! There is no 'we'.
 I am not you. I'm Riggan fucking
 Thomson.

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
 No. You're Birdman. Because without
 me, all that's left is "you". A
 sad, selfish, mediocre actor,
 grasping--

Riggan points his finger and sends the poster flying,
 spearing it on a coat rack, piercing Birdman right through
 the heart. Finally, silence. Until...

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
 What the hell did you do that for?
 I liked that poster.

A confused Riggan looks over to the wall, where the lamp on
 the floor is creating a shadow of his figure. Only in the
 shadow, it appears as if Riggan is wearing the Birdman
 costume. Stunned, Riggan slowly lifts one arm and in the
 shadow we see a wing.

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
 It's always 'we' brother.

The television turns on by itself, playing an episode of the
 original Birdman cartoon. Riggan points his fingers at the tv
 and sends it hurling at the shadow. Then he proceeds to
 destroy everything in his room with his telekinetic powers.

We slowly pan to see that, behind Riggan, Jake stands on the other side of the half-opened door. We push in on Jake, watching in shock. The camera turns and becomes Jake's POV...

35 INT. HALLWAY - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

35

...and now, from his view, we see Riggan yelling at the shadow.

RIGGAN
Fuck you! Fuck you!

He picks up a chair and throws it down. He then picks up the newspaper from the floor and tossing it all around. And now we understand that he is not using telepathy. He has been using only his hands. Completely mad. As Riggan turns to pick up something else, he spots Jake on the other side of the door. He immediately calms himself and walks over.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)
What's up?

JAKE
Um... Well. Two hours to curtain.
Why don't you rest a little bit?

RIGGAN
Yeah. Sure.

JAKE
Last preview, buddy. We're almost there.

RIGGAN
Okay.

JAKE
How ya doin?

RIGGAN
Good. Great.

JAKE
Good. That's good.
(A beat.)
The, uh, money came through. I just have to transfer it to the account.

RIGGAN
Oh, that's terrific...

JAKE
Okay. Well, I'm gonna do that.

(He stares at Riggan who seems about to collapse.)
You know I'm proud of you, right?
This took balls. And you did it.

Riggan nods. An exhausted sadness in his eyes.

RIGGAN
I can't do this anymore, Jake.

JAKE
What?

RIGGAN
I think I'm gonna cancel the preview. I'm exhausted.

JAKE
It's a joke, right?
(He forces a laugh.)
Good one, Riggan.

RIGGAN
I'm starting to believe that this is not for me. The applause is... lukewarm. I think they're laughing at me.

JAKE
What are you--? Listen. There's a three block line of people waiting to see you. We are sold out. It's a full house.

RIGGAN
Really?

JAKE
Yes. And the French ambassador is coming. And the prince of Saudi Arabia, with one of his wives. And... I wasn't going to tell you this, but-- Martin Scorsese. He's casting for his new film. But don't tell anyone, okay? This is between you and me.

RIGGAN
Okay. I'll be ready.

Riggan smiles. He has forgotten about his existential doubts. A worried Jake closes the door. He walks a few steps and finds Laura and Lesley. They've been listening to his conversation with Riggan.

LESLEY

How is he?

JAKE

He'll be okay.

LESLEY

Poor creature.

LAURA

Is it true? Scorsese?

JAKE

Yes. And the new Pope too.

(Beat.)

They both understand.

LAURA

You're an asshole, Jake.

JAKE

I'm the one keeping this boat
afloat.

LESLEY

So there is no line of people out
there?

JAKE

I don't know. Now go and get ready.
That's your job.

(He begins to walk.)

I'll better invest in a taco truck,
or a strip joint near the airport.

Laura leaves. We follow Lesley up to Riggan's dressing room. She knocks on the door. Nothing. Silence. She half-opens the door and, from behind her, we see Riggan examining his right hand. He has blood falling from the palm to the wrist.

LESLEY

Are you okay?

RIGGAN

(Smiles.)

Yeah, I-- This is nothing. Shaving.

He cleans his hand against his trousers.

LESLEY

I just want to say I'm sorry.

RIGGAN

For what?

LESLEY
I knew what Mike was capable of,
and I brought him in, anyway.

RIGGAN
You did good.

Lesley nods. A beat.

LESLEY
Tomorrow's my first opening night
on Broadway.

RIGGAN
Mine too.

LESLEY
And I want you to know that,
whatever happens, I'll always be
grateful to you for that.

RIGGAN
Me too. It's going to be great.
Full house.

She looks at him with tender eyes. Then we follow her along the corridor until she passes by Mike's dressing room. Mike half-opens the door and sees Lesley walking by. He has a black eye. He waits for Lesley to be completely gone, and then he comes out of his dressing room and we follow him up the stairs to...

36 EXT. ROOFTOP - THEATER - DUSK

36

...the rooftop. He finds Sam standing on the cornice, looking at the street.

MIKE
For fuck's sake, just jump already.

Sam stares out, a smile creeping over her face.

SAM
How did you know I'd be up here?

MIKE
I didn't. I was just hoping.

Silence. Mike walks up next to her and stares out as well.

SAM

Where's Lesley?

MIKE
Moving on.

SAM
Smart girl...

MIKE
I appreciate that.

A beat.

SAM
Ready for the last preview?
(Noticing his black eye.)
Who did that to you?

Mike smiles. No answer.

SAM (CONT'D)
Could have been anybody, I guess.
(After a beat.)
I'm sort of hoping it was Lesley.

He barely says no, smiling, and lights a cigarette. She understands.

SAM (CONT'D)
Oh, don't tell me...

Silence.

MIKE
What's the worst thing he ever did
to you?

Sam is surprised by the question. She thinks for a moment.

SAM
He was never around, so...

MIKE
That was--?

SAM
No. That was-- Who gives a shit. It
was the way he tried to make up for
it by constantly trying to convince
me I was special.
(A beat.)
What about you?

MIKE

My dad?

SAM

Yeah.

MIKE

He pretended I was his son.

She stares him down. Silence.

SAM

So, what happens now?

MIKE

I have no idea...

SAM

Yeah...

A beat.

MIKE

He was right, though.

SAM

About what?

MIKE

About your being special. You're hanging around here trying to make yourself invisible behind that fragile little fuck up routine. But you can't. You're anything but invisible. You're big. And you're sort of this really great mess, a candle burning at both ends, and no amount of booze or pills is gonna hide that.

Sam tosses Mike's cigarette over the balcony, and kisses him. He leans into the kiss.

MAN'S VOICE

(From below.)

Jesus Fuck!

She suddenly pulls away.

SAM

It's a good thing you're an actor and not a writer cause that little speech was just like, Oprah... Hallmark... R. Kelly bad.

She kisses him lightly one more time and then walks away.
When she gets to the door she stops and leans on the frame.

SAM (CONT'D)
Truth or dare?

MIKE
Truth.

SAM
No.

MIKE
Truth.

SAM
No. Truth or dare?

The slightest smile as she exits through the door, and after
a short pause, Mike follows...

37 INT. HALLWAYS - THEATRE - CONTINUOUS

37

...along a darkened hallway. They reach a tiny wooden door
and Sam leads the way through it.

MIKE
Do you have any idea where you're
going?

SAM
Absolutely not.

She continues on until she gets to...

38 INT. ABOVE STAGE - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

38

...the "grid" above stage where the lights are located. We
can see, below us, the empty seats of the auditorium and the
kitchen set.

MIKE
What now...?

Mike reaches up to kiss her. She stops him.

SAM
How do you do it?

MIKE
What?

SAM

How do you go out there and pretend
to be someone else in front of all
those people?

MIKE

I don't pretend. Not out there.
Just about every place else, but
never out there.

SAM

Good to know.

They stare at one another...

MIKE

What are we doing here?

SAM

What do you mean?

MIKE

I mean, what are we doing here?

She moves in.

SAM

Adrenaline...

They kiss. The camera begins to drift down toward the
stage...

RIGGAN (O.S.)

Fucking teenager.

As the camera continues down from the grid, we discover an
auditorium full of people staring at the actors on stage.

RIGGAN (O.S) (CONT'D)

By the time I got to the hospital,
the kid was dead. He was off in a
corner laid out on a gurney. We
took the old couple up to the O.R..
They were a mess. We worked like
hell on them for most of the
night...

We pan along the auditorium back to the stage to find Riggan,
Mike, Lesley and Laura in the kitchen.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)

When we were done, we wrapped them in full body casts. The husband was depressed. Even when I told him his wife was gonna pull through, he was still depressed. So, I got up to his mouth hole and asked him, and he told me it was because he couldn't see her through the eye holes. Can you imagine? I'm telling you, the man's heart was breaking because he couldn't turn his goddamn head and see his goddamn wife.

LESLEY

(In genuine tears.)

That's terrible.

(Beat.)

Perfect. And terrible.

She is crushed. Laura holds Lesley, trying to control her own emotion.

RIGGAN

(Taking this in.)

Yeah. So I guess what we have to ask ourselves is... What do we talk about when we talk about love?

The lights go to a blackout and the audience applauds as some scene change music plays. As we follow Riggan off stage, the lights are turned on again, but now they have an orange mood. Lesley is the only one on stage, doing a monologue.

LESLEY

Mel and I have been together five years, been married for four. But it was Ed who taught me something no one else could... He taught me what it felt like to really feel loved. And the terrible thing is that if something happened to Mel or myself, if something happened to either one of us tomorrow, I think the other one would grieve for a while, you know, but then would go out and love again, have someone else soon enough. All this-- All of this love we're talking about... it would just be a memory. Maybe not even a memory. Am I wrong? I mean, I don't know anything. And I'm the first one to admit it.

A Dresser waits in the wings to help Riggan with his change.

DRESSER
That was amazing!

Riggan looks proud. Things are finally going well. He undresses to his underwear and puts on a robe and his moccasins, as the stage begins to revolve. Laura, in costume, walks up beside him. Over the following dialogue, the kitchen gives way to the extravagant garden set we saw before.

LAURA
(A bit distant.)
It's actually going well.

RIGGAN
Yeah.
(A beat.)
Hey. I think we have to talk.

LAURA
(Sad smile.)
No. We don't.

Riggan nods.

RIGGAN
Right.
(Beat.)
We will eventually, though, 'cause that's the only way I get to say I'm sorry. I really am.

Silence.

LAURA
We could've made good parents.

RIGGAN
Horrible. We would've been just--

LAURA
Awful. Would have raised, like...

RIGGAN
...a serial killer...

LAURA
...or Justin Bieber.
(She smiles at him.)
I'm not really the housewife type anyway. I thought I could be a mom. My body seems to disagree.

The lights come up and Laura walks onto the stage.

LAURA (CONT'D)
(Back to him.)
You were right. This was fun.

Riggan watches her go, but something else grabs his attention. We pan across the stage to see Sam and Mike on the other side. They talk and laugh. Sam kisses Mike softly. Mike playfully grabs her ass.

We pan back to Riggan. His expression morphs from broken-hearted to rage. He marches over to a stage hand.

RIGGAN
You have a cigarette?

The stage hand holds out a pack, Riggan takes one.

STAGE HAND
You need a light?

Riggan snatches the lighter and storms out through the hallway, and out the back door of the theater to...

39 EXT. AN ALLEY WAY - OUTSIDE THE THEATER - CONTINUOUS

39

...the alley. Down at the end, we can see the tourists making their way about the streets. Riggan lights the cigarette and leans back against the stage door trying to calm himself.

RIGGAN
Breathing in, I calm myself.
Breathing out, I ease myself.

But this is New York City. A fluorescent light buzzes above his head. Taxis honk their horns. The sound of pedestrians yelling at one another. All fueling his agitation.

Riggan checks his watch. He pulls one last drag from the cigarette before he tosses it, and turns to head back in, only to realize the door has locked. He tries to pull it open to no avail. He begins to knock loudly on the door. There is no response. He knocks louder. Nothing.

He is turning to walk away when he realizes that his robe is caught in the door. He checks his watch again and now is beginning to panic. He tries to tear at the robe but the terry cloth is too strong for him to rip. Frantically, he looks around for an answer. No answer. No time. He pulls the robe off of him

and, wearing only his underwear and moccasins, he charges down the alley way toward...

40 EXT. STREET - CONTINUOUS

40

...the street. Now, rushing down the block in his underwear. A tourist spots him.

TOURIST
Hey, aren't you...?

RIGGAN
I'm sorry. I can't really--

TOURIST
Riggan Thompson! Holy Shit! Let me get an autograph.

Riggan marches on as a few more people begin to notice. The Tourist runs in front of him, forcing him to stop.

TOURIST (CONT'D)
Come on, man. Don't be a dick. Let me have an autograph.

The man produces a pen and a magazine from his pocket. More people begin to gather...

MAN ON STREET
Birdman!

Seeing no other way out, Riggan signs the autograph.

TOURIST
Dude! You fuckin' rock!

Directly in front of him stand a lady and her two kids.

LADY
Can we take one picture?

RIGGAN
Are you kidding me?

KID #1
Why is he naked?

LADY
One picture...

KID #2
I can see his weenie.

Riggan tries to get past them, but a crowd has formed. A swarm of cell phones begin to glow like fireflies.

LADY
(To her kids.)
Get next to him!

RIGGAN
Give me a fucking break, lady.

The kids run up next to him. Even more people crowding around. Riggan puts up his middle finger, just as the Lady takes the shot. He shoves the kids aside and moves on.

WOMAN ON STREET
He looks so old in person.

MAN ON STREET
(From across the street.)
You suck!

RIGGAN
Fuck you!

Riggan pushes through the crowd to get to the lobby. The people begin to chant. Dozens of cell phones recording him.

CROWD
Bird-man! Bird-man! Bird-man!

Riggan pushes his way through to the lobby doors...

41 INT. LOBBY - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

41

...to be stopped by the vision of Ralph in a wheelchair. His head wrapped in a bandage. A man in a suit next to him.

RIGGAN
Jesus Christ! What're you doing here?

RALPH
Waiting for Jake. This is Mr. Roth, my attorney.

Riggan continues walking toward the auditorium. Ralph and Mr. Roth follow him.

MR. ROTH
We're pursuing financial remuneration for the injuries Mr. Pinkus suffered while rehearsing your--

RIGGAN
I have a play to do.

RALPH
I'm going to ruin you!

Riggan storms toward the auditorium, but is stopped by an old Usher.

OLD USHER
I'm sorry sir, you're going to have--

Riggan shoves the old lady aside and enters...

42 INT. AUDITORIUM - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

42

...the theater. Riggan stands in the back among the audience. He sees the "rain" falling on the stage. The "Motel" sign is lit. Mike and Lesley are in bed, for the motel scene, waiting for the knock on the door. With nothing else to do, Riggan yells his line from the back of the auditorium...

RIGGAN
Knock knock knock! Terri! Terri!

The audience turns to see Riggan standing in his underwear. They begin to murmur and laugh and point at him.

Riggan marches down the aisle. He looks haggard and covered with perspiration.

Lesley and Mike, confused, come out of bed.

LESLEY
Ed! What are you doing here?

RIGGAN
Why? I need you to tell me why. I lived for you-- I worshipped you...

MIKE
Listen Ed, I know this is hard but--
-

RIGGAN
Fuck you. Shut up. Fuck you.

Giggles from the audience. Riggan turns threateningly and points to an audience member on the aisle who is giggling at him.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)

Shut up!

The guy stops smiling. The audience goes silent. Riggan arrives at the apron of the stage. Annie from the wings slides the gun towards him. Riggan grabs it and points it at Mike.

LESLEY

Eddie! Please!

Riggan climbs onto the stage. Exhausted. He goes to Mike and, with a last effort, pushes him lamely.

RIGGAN

What's wrong with me? Why do I end up having to beg people to love me?

LESLEY

Ed. Eddie. Please... Give me the gun.

We pan to the wings where Jake is staring in disbelief. His cellphone begins to vibrate, and he answers.

JAKE

Yeah.

(A beat.)

What?... No no no no no no no. Wait there. I'm coming out in--

He walks toward the hallway and we follow him...

43 INT. HALLWAY - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

43

...through the corridor.

JAKE

No. Wait. Wait for me. I'll be there in a second.

(Beat.)

What is that, a threat?

(Beat.)

What wheelchair?

(Beat.)

Wait. Don't hang up. Mr. Roth, we can discuss-- Hello?... Hello?...

He goes out one of the exits and we are left with the silence of the empty hallway. After a few seconds, the sound of the gunshot from the scene echoes through the theater. The audience applauds. The camera starts to move forward. A few seconds later Riggan takes over the POV with his bloody long wig and the fake gun. We follow up to...

44 INT. RIGGAN'S DRESSING ROOM - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

44

...his dressing room. He puts on a robe. He walks to his refrigerator without acknowledging Sam who is sitting on the couch, scribbling her dashes on the toilet paper once again. Riggan takes out a plastic container of bologna and a jar of mustard. He sits in front of his dressing table, peels open the bologna and opens the jar of mustard. Slice by slice, he dips the bologna in the mustard and shoves it into his mouth.

SAM

Dad...?

RIGGAN

(Looking up.)

Hey. How ya doin'?

SAM

Are you okay?

RIGGAN

Why?

SAM

I don't know. You seem--

RIGGAN

(Eating.)

I'm good. This is good.

(Holding out a piece.)

You want some?

SAM

I'm good.

RIGGAN

Great. Great.

He continues to eat. She tries to fill the odd silence.

SAM

So. Opening night, tomorrow.

RIGGAN

Yeah.

SAM

That's exciting, huh?

RIGGAN

Yeah. Well... I don't know. The previews have been a train wreck. We haven't been able to get through a performance without a raging fire... or a raging hard-on. I'm not really sleeping, you know, at all. And I'm pretty much broke. Oh, and also, this play feels like a miniature, deformed version of myself that keeps following me around, hitting me in the balls with a tiny hammer.

(Beat.)

Sorry, what was your question?

SAM

(Looking through phone.)

Never mind... Tonight wasn't bad. It was weird. But that's sort of cool. People seemed to like it.

Silence. Riggan notices the toilet paper.

RIGGAN

What are you doing? Some homework?

SAM

No. I don't-- When I was in rehab, they made us do this.

RIGGAN

Really...

SAM

Yeah. These dashes, represent the six billion years the planet has existed. Each dash represents 100 years.

She unravels the roll and we see that there are thousands of black marks running along the toilet paper. She takes the last two panels and tears them off.

SAM (CONT'D)

And this...

(Hands them to him.)

...is supposed to represent the entire time us humans have been here. One hundred and fifty thousand years. That's it.

(Beat.)

I guess they were trying to remind us that that's what all our egos and self- obsession are worth.

Riggan stares at the paper, and then at Sam.

RIGGAN
(Casually.)
I was a shitty father, wasn't I?

SAM
No. You were a--
(She stops herself.)
You were fine.

He stops chewing and stares out.

RIGGAN
Fine... You're right. I am just
"fine". Adorably mediocre.

He smiles to her sadly, and then he wipes the mustard from his face with the piece of toilet paper.

SAM
Dad!

RIGGAN
What?

Sam looks at the ruined toilet paper in his hands.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)
Oh... Shit. I'm sorry.

SAM
(Smiling.)
It's okay. You just destroyed the
entire human race in one blow.

Riggan looks at her with the saddest of expressions.

SAM (CONT'D)
Dad.
(She hesitates.)
Do you know you're becoming a
trending topic?

RIGGAN
Really? What does that mean?

Sam searches for something on her iPhone and then hands it to Riggan. Riggan looks at the phone and sees a hand-held video of himself in the streets in his underwear.

SAM
350,000 views in less than an hour.
Believe it or not, this is power.

Riggan looks at more footage, seemingly confused. After a moment, the phone vibrates and the video is interrupted by a text message, which reads "Truth or Dare?"

RIGGAN
It's for you.

She grabs the phone and looks at the screen. Then at her father. Riggan is staring at her. She looks down.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)
Go ahead...

SAM
(Hesitant.)
Are you...?

RIGGAN
Go.

A sympathetic smile. An understanding. Sam exits.

Riggan stares into the mirror absently. His eyes locked on his reflection trying to find himself in the image. Then he spots a vase with dying roses, the same roses he flung to the ground previously.

He gets up and goes into the bathroom. He pulls off the long wig and the mustache. He washes his face. Then he opens a small bottle and uses the liquid to scrub his goatee. The dark dye begins to run out, leaving only white hair. For the first time we see that Riggan has a white beard.

He puts on new clothes and comes out of the bathroom. He grabs a beige raincoat and heads out of the dressing room and into...

45 INT. HALLWAY - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

45

...the hallway. As he passes by Mike's door he can hear Sam and Mike. They're trying to be as quiet as possible, but we can hear them flirting and laughing.

He pauses for a moment but continues on. After a few seconds, his phone vibrates. He looks at it. A text from Jake reads: "Have you seen this??? Awesome!!!" He clicks the attachment and sees the, now infamous, video of his underwear escapade in the street. We zoom in until the image fills the screen, when we finally pull away, we discover that...

46 INT. RUM HOUSE - LATER

46

...Riggan's video is being played now in a television in the bar. We see the MTV logo on the bottom of the screen and a video caption that reads: "Birdman goes viral, 930.000 views and counting". The camera pans to find Riggan sitting at the bar, drunk. He is one of the few customers. He polishes off his drink.

RIGGAN

Let me have another one.

BARTENDER

You got it.

The bartender pours another whiskey for Riggan. A waiter steps up to the bar. The bartender points to a martini.

BARTENDER (CONT'D)

(To the waiter.)

That's going over to Ms. Dickinson.

Riggan's head tilts at the mention of the name. He looks over to see Tabitha sitting at a table, scratching in her notebook.

RIGGAN

(Hands the waiter a
bill.)

I got it. She's a friend of mine.

The waiter pockets the money and gives Riggan the drink. He walks it over to Tabitha and places it down in front of her. Not looking up, she pulls the drink closer and takes a sip.

Riggan sits down across from her. She looks up and immediately recognizes him. He takes out the Carver cocktail napkin and pushes it in front of her. She looks at him, and then down to the napkin. She reads it in silence.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)

(Re: The napkin.)

That was twenty years before I put
on that damned costume.

A pause. Then she pushes the napkin back toward him.

TABITHA

I don't care.

RIGGAN

I'm just saying, when you come
tomorrow night, I want you--

TABITHA

It doesn't matter.

RIGGAN

What are you--

TABITHA

I'm going to destroy your play.

RIGGAN

You haven't even seen it. I don't--
Did I do something to offend you?

TABITHA

As a matter of fact you did. You took up space in a theater which otherwise might have been used on something worthwhile.

RIGGAN

But you don't even know if it's--

TABITHA

That's true. I haven't read a word of it, or even seen a preview, but after the opening tomorrow I'm going to turn in the worst review anybody has ever read. And I'm going to close your play. Would you like to know why? Because I hate you. And everyone you represent. Entitled. Spoiled. Selfish. Children. Blissfully untrained, unversed and unprepared to even attempt real art. Handing each other awards for cartoons and pornography. Measuring your worth in weekends Well, this is the theater, and you don't get to come in here and pretend you can write, direct and act in your own propaganda piece without going through me first. So, break a leg.

Tabitha goes back to her writing. Riggan sits for a moment.

RIGGAN

What has to happen in someone's life, for them to end up becoming a critic?

She looks up at him.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)

Whatcha writin'? You reviewin' a play? Was it good? Bad? Did you even see it? Lemme read.

He snatches the notebook from her.

TABITHA

I will call the police.

RIGGAN

No you won't. Let's read your review!

(He scans the notebook.)

"Callow". A label. "Lackluster". Label. "Marginalia". Sounds like you need penicillin to clear that up. None the less... label.

(Looks to Tabitha.)

All labels. You're a lazy fucker aren't you?

(Looks one last time at the notebook.)

Epistemological vertigo?

Tabitha wants to reach for the notebook, but her pride won't let her. Riggan takes a flower from a vase at the center of the table.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)

You know what this is? You don't, do you? You can't even see it if you don't label it. You mistake those sounds in your head for true knowledge.

TABITHA

Are you finished?

RIGGAN

(Wrinkling one of the pages.)

Nothin' about intention, structure, technique. Just crappy opinions backed up by crappy comparisons. You're incapable of writing more than a couple of paragraphs, and you risk nothing of yourself.

(He tears out the page and tosses the notebook.)

Well, I'm an actor and this play has cost me everything. So you can take your cowardly, malicious, shittily written reviews and shove them up your...

(Showing her the wrinkled page.)

..wrinkly, tight ass.

Riggan wears a proud smile. And suddenly, Tabitha begins to smile with him.

TABITHA
You think you're an actor?
(Calls to the waiter.)
Eddie!

Eddie the waiter approaches the table.

WAITER
Yeah, Mrs. Dickinson?

TABITHA
Give us some Shakespeare.

WAITER
No problem. Got anything in mind?

Tabitha looks over at Riggan picking the perfect verse.

TABITHA
The Scottish Play. Act five...

WAITER
Tomorrow, and tomorrow, and
tomorrow, Creeps in this petty pace
from day to day, To the last
syllable of recorded time; And all
our yesterdays have lighted fools.
The way to dusty death...

He is brilliant. The monologue is perfectly played and powerful. Riggan being mercilessly reminded of his mediocrity... by Eddie the waiter.

WAITER (CONT'D)
...Out, out, brief candle! Life's
but a walking shadow, a poor
player, That struts and frets his
hour upon the stage, And then is
heard no more. It is a tale told by
an idiot, full of sound and fury...
Signifying nothing.

A few drunks clap at the beautiful performance. Then, a powerful silence rings out for a moment, until...

TABITHA
Thank you, Eddie.

WAITER
You got it.

TABITHA
 (To Riggan. A derisive
 laugh.)
 You're no actor. You're a
 celebrity. Let's be clear on that.

Tabitha rises from her seat and grabs her things.

TABITHA (CONT'D)
 I'm going to kill your play.

She walks away. Riggan sits numb. After a moment, he reaches over and gulps down Tabitha's entire martini, gin pouring out the sides of his mouth. Unaware, he slams the empty martini glass on top of the Carver napkin and gets up. We follow him out onto...

47 EXT. STREET - CONTINUOUS

47

...the street, where he walks through the theater district. Tired. Drunk. Empty. Neon lights all around him. A crazy, old homeless man passes by in the opposite direction shouting furiously. Riggan keeps walking until he arrives at a bench, with a tree behind. Everything is quiet. Riggan sits on the bench, lost. We begin to tilt up, slowly, toward a tall tree. We move closer into the branches and the green leaves. Silence.

Night turns into day. The sounds of the city disappear and birds begin to sing. The branches now caressed by golden shafts of morning sun. Finally, we tilt down slowly and find...

48 EXT. STREET - DAY.

48

...Riggan still sleeping on the bench. He looks like a bum. His raincoat is dirty and wet.

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
 God. You look like shit, brother.
 You get that mongoloid look when
 you're hung over, don't you?

Riggan opens an eye. He scratches his hair.

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
 Let's go. Get up. It's a beautiful
 day.

Riggan sits up slowly. He is really hung over.

BIRDMAN (V.O.)

Stand up! Forget about the times.
 Everyone else has. So you're not a
 great actor... Who cares?!! You're
 much more than that. Fuck! You
 tower over all these theater
 douchebags. You're a movie star! A
 Global force! Don't you get it?

Riggan stands up and begins to stumble forward. We pan around to find Birdman (a stronger Riggan wearing a cool Birdman outfit), following behind him.

BIRDMAN

You spent your whole life building
 a reputation and a bank account,
 and now they're both blown. So
 what? Fuck it. We make a come back.
 Something huge. Take what belongs
 to us. Take back the spotlight.
 Magazine covers and billboards.
 Happy meals with Birdman dolls.
 Remember that? That's who you are.
 That's who we are!

Riggan just marches on. People and cars pass by, but nobody notices Birdman. Riggan tries to ignore him.

BIRDMAN (CONT'D)

C'mon, buddy. Tell me we're going
 back to the big leagues. Let's do
 this. Shave off that pathetic
 goatee, and put the mask back on!
 Batman my balls. We'll start a new
 franchise. Birdman: Phoenix Rising.
 Trust me! A billion world wide.
 Swear to God.

Riggan keeps walking. Birdman, insistent, chases, until suddenly he begins to flutter off the ground.

BIRDMAN

Do you hear me? You can do
 anything! You're an icon!

Desperate, Birdman flies a bit higher around him.

BIRDMAN (CONT'D)

You're bigger than life. You save
 people from their boring, miserable
 lives...

The camera pans to the street in front of them. People carry out their everyday routines. There is a deli, a souvenir shop, a small bank...

BIRDMAN (O.S.) (CONT'D)
 ...You make them jump, laugh, cry,
 shit their pants... All you have to
 do is snap your fingers and...

Riggan snaps his fingers, once, twice, and the bank suddenly explodes. The sound is so loud that it seems to belong to another movie. The earth shakes. People run. Dust all over. Fire. An unsteady camera pans back to Birdman.

BIRDMAN
 (Excited.)
 That's what I'm talking about! That
 is cool! Explosive! Big, fast,
 loud!
 (He turns directly to the
 camera and talks about
 the audience.)
 Look at them. They love that shit!
 They starve for blood and action,
 not this artsy-fartsy-philosophical
 bullshit!

We hear a loud roar, and the camera pans to discover a huge alien about to crash a cab against the asphalt. Birdman uses his powerful blow to send the alien flying away.

BIRDMAN
 And when you shout "whooaa!"...
 (Riggan shouts "Whooaa!")
 ...it explodes in the eardrum of
 millions. Your power is unlimited.

Riggan slows down his pace, as he starts to listen.

BIRDMAN (CONT'D)
 You glimmered on 3000 screens, over
 5 continents, in 47 countries at
 the same time. You are ubiquitous.
 You're a God! You can do it again.
 You can soar above all of them.

Riggan suddenly begins to levitate.

BIRDMAN
 There you go, you mother fucker!
 See? Gravity doesn't even apply to
 you.

The camera flies up with Riggan as he floats above the street. There is something magical in his ascension, gently impelled by the breeze. A beautiful backlight makes his body glow. Birdman flutters around him.

BIRDMAN (CONT'D)

Listen to me. We gotta go back! We have to do this. We have to end it on our terms. With a grand gesture.

A strange light suddenly palpitates in Riggan's eyes. Something makes sense in what Birdman is telling him.

The camera becomes Riggan's POV. He looks down to see the people on the street, watching him in awe.

BIRDMAN (O.S.) (CONT'D)

We'll go back. We'll show them how much they're going to miss us. Flames. Icarus. Sacrifice...

We tilt up again to Riggan's face. He has a plan.

BIRDMAN (O.S.) (CONT'D)

Let's go back one more time and show them what we're capable of. You can do it. You're Birdman. Do you hear me? You're...

A GUY'S VOICE (O.S.)

Birdman!

And as the camera pulls away, we discover Birdman is gone and Riggan is standing on the ledge of a tall building. The camera tilts down and we see that more people have gathered around, and more cars has stopped, and they all point at Riggan, worried about the situation.

A guy wearing shorts, a Bob Marley t-shirt and a robe opens his window, one floor below Riggan, and looks up at him.

GUY

Dude, what are you doing?

Riggan looks down at the people on the street far below.

GUY (CONT'D)

You okay, buddy? Do you want me to call someone?

We pan to a lady on her balcony filming Riggan with her phone.

LADY

Is this for real, or you're shooting a film?

RIGGAN

A film.

The lady looks around but sees nothing.

LADY

Oh, you people are full of shit.

She goes into her apartment.

GUY

I'm calling 911.

The guy goes inside his apartment.

RIGGAN

One more time...

Now, from the door of the rooftop, a good neighbor calmly approaches Riggan.

GOOD NEIGHBOR

Hi, sir. Can I help you? You should be careful.

RIGGAN

Sorry. Can't talk. I'm late.

(Murmuring.)

Music.

Some underscoring music begins to sound. The neighbor is now close to him and helps Riggan step down from the edge on to the floor of the rooftop.

GOOD NEIGHBOR

Are you alright? Do you want me to call someone? Do you know where to go?

Riggan closes his eyes for a moment as the camera moves slowly toward him. He opens his eyes. The music begins to swell. Riggan stands up straight and proud, and in a voice that sounds like Birdman...

RIGGAN

Yes. I know where to go.

He turns and begins to run on the rooftop. The music is rousing. As he runs, he holds out his arms, spreading them wide. The camera runs behind him, until suddenly...

Riggan jumps, and the camera jumps after him. He rapidly falls toward the street, toward the asphalt. But in his face there is no fear. No. He spreads his arms again and...

He takes flight, soaring high over Manhattan. The music becomes epic. There is something beautiful about this broken man flying like a superhero. We fly next to him, and we can see below the spectacular sight that is Manhattan, until...

49 EXT. THEATER - CONTINUOUS

49

...he finally lands on 45th street and calmly approaches the theater. An Usher acknowledges him with a look of surprise.

USHER

Mr. Thomson. I think you forgot to-

-

RIGGAN

Stop the music.

The music stops.

USHER

I beg your pardon?

Riggan enters the theater.

The confused Usher watches him go by, as he points to the street. We pan to see a taxi driver coming out of his car, running like a mad man toward us.

We stay with the Usher and the taxi driver as they argue. They take it inside the lobby, but we remain out front.

Day turns to night, igniting the lights of the marquee, which reflect off of the lobby doors. We hear wild applause coming from inside the theater. Seconds later, the doors of the theater open and the audience files out for intermission.

MAN

(Tweeting on his phone.)

It's really good.

WOMAN

I know. I can't believe it...

We begin to move up, outside the theater. We see the marquee of the play that reads, "What We Talk When We Talk About Love". Above the title, in smaller print, "Riggan Thomson and Mike Shiner". Below on a banner, "Opening Night".

We keep climbing until we arrive at Riggan's dressing room window. We push in to find...

50 INT. RIGGAN'S DRESSING ROOM - THEATER - EVENING

50

... that the room is full of roses and cards. Riggan lies on the sofa, hugging a cushion. He is wearing the long wig and mustache for the motel scene.

Sylvia appears in the doorway.

SYLVIA

Wow, that is just NASCAR hot.

He smiles at her.

SYLVIA (CONT'D)

I just wanted to come say hello.
It's going great out there. You're
so good. I mean it. You're-- I
really mean it.

RIGGAN

Come here. Sit next to me.

ANNIE ON SPEAKERS

This is your five minutes.

SYLVIA

Do you need to--?

RIGGAN

I'm fine. Sit.

She does.

SYLVIA

Look at all these roses.

SYLVIA (CONT'D)

You hate roses... RIGGAN I hate
roses...

She laughs. He watches her, something odd in his expression.

SYLVIA (CONT'D)

Are you okay? You seem-- I don't
know, you seem abnormally calm.

RIGGAN

I am calm. I'm great. I spent most
of the day observing how
beautifully this pile of dirty
clothes was lit by the warm
afternoon sun.

(A tiny smile.)

So beautiful.

Sylvia, teasing him, closes her eyes and imitates Riggan's meditation posture.

SYLVIA

(Mocking him.)

Oh yes. God is those purplish light dots I see between my eyes and my eyelids.

RIGGAN

You know? I have this voice that talks to me and tells me the truth. It's comforting, and scary.

A beat.

SYLVIA

I'm going to pretend I didn't hear you say that.

RIGGAN

Okay.

SYLVIA

(Changing the subject.)

You wouldn't believe the crowd outside. They said, some people paid up to 500 dollars a ticket.

He sits down.

RIGGAN

You wanna hear something funny?

SYLVIA

Sure.

RIGGAN

Do you remember our last anniversary party?

SYLVIA

Seriously? You're going to ruin a nice moment with that?

RIGGAN

Do you remember the party?

SYLVIA

The party where you fucked Janet Rossbach in our bed? Yeah, it rings a bell.

RIGGAN

Yeah, well. Let's skip over that part for a minute.

SYLVIA

Gladly.

RIGGAN

After you threw the guests out of the house, and the furniture out of the window. You locked yourself in the bathroom.

SYLVIA

I remember. Why are we--

RIGGAN

I drove down to Malibu. I sat on the beach for a while. Just... staring out at the ocean.

SYLVIA

Riggan...

RIGGAN

Until I walked straight into the water and tried to drown myself.

Silence. Sylvia stares at Riggan, surprised.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)

I was in up to my chest when I felt the first one. On my back, like somebody was holding a frying pan against me. And then my chest, and my legs. The water was full of jellyfish. I fought my way out of the water, and I started rolling around the sand like a maniac... crying.

Sylvia doesn't know how to react.

SYLVIA

You said it was a sunburn.

RIGGAN

(Smiling.)

And you believed me.

SYLVIA

To be honest, I didn't give a shit.

RIGGAN

I love you. And I love Sam.

SYLVIA

I know.

Silence. They stare at each other.

RIGGAN

I never should have video taped Sam's birth. First of all because you and Sam both look like shit in that video. But mostly because I missed the moment. I should have just been there with the two of you. Present in my own life. So I'd have it. But, I don't. I don't have any of it.

SYLVIA

You have Sam.

RIGGAN

No, I don't.

SYLVIA

Listen, she's just--

RIGGAN

No, I understand. She needed a father and she got one shamefully successful youtube video. Pretty pathetic.

SYLVIA

(Putting a finger on Riggan's lips.)

Shhh... There are more pathetic things than that. That mustache, for example.

She kisses him.

ANNIE ON SPEAKERS

Places for act two. Places.

SYLVIA

Riggan...

RIGGAN

You should get back to your seat.
You don't want to miss what's next.

Sylvia lingers for a moment, and not knowing what to say, she exits. Riggan opens a drawer and takes out a black case. He

gently opens the lid. Inside a revolver. He takes some bullets out of a box and one by one loads them into the chamber as he does his vocal exercises into the mirror.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)
 Twenty little leopards laughed at
 two lofty lions. Twenty little
 leopards laughed at two lofty
 lions. Twenty little leopards...
 laughed.

He stares at the dressing room door, and with his telekinetic powers he opens it. He snaps the cylinder into the gun and exits out into...

51 INT. HALLWAY - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

51

...the hallway. He paces deliberately, gun in hand.

A technician goes by in the opposite direction.

TECHNICIAN
 Break a leg, Mr. Thomson.

Riggan ignores him and continues through to the...

52 INT. BACKSTAGE - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

52

...backstage area. Annie immediately hustles over to him holding up the brain mechanism. He walks right by her.

RIGGAN
 (Brushing her off.)
 I don't need it.

Annie doesn't seem to understand. She stays there, holding the device. Riggan takes his place outside the motel door. We pan toward the audience. The auditorium is full. The audience in complete silence.

Riggan knocks firmly on the door. Silence again. Then...

RIGGAN (CONT'D)
 Terri! Terri!
 (Beat.)
 I know you're in there!

He barges through the door and onto...

53 INT. STAGE - THEATER - CONTINUOUS

53

...the stage. The motel room as we saw it before. Mike and Lesley jump out of the bed.

LESLEY

Ed! What are you doing here?

RIGGAN

(Almost whispering.)

Why? I need you to tell me why. I lived for you-- I worshipped you...

MIKE

Listen Ed, I know this is hard but-

-

Riggan raises one hand to silence Mike. Mike looks at him, confused. His eyes narrow on the gun. There is no red plug.

Dead silence. An eerie electricity in the theater.

RIGGAN

What's wrong with me? Why do I end up having to beg people to love me?

LESLEY

Ed. Eddie. Please... Give me the gun.

She begins to cry.

LESLEY (CONT'D)

Just look at me. I was drowning. I was not capable of-- You deserve to be loved. You do.

RIGGAN

I just wanted to be what you wanted.

(Beat.)

Now I spend every fucking minute praying to be someone else. Someone I'm not. Anyone...

MIKE

Put down the gun, Ed. She just doesn't love you anymore.

RIGGAN

(To Lesley.)

You don't, do you?

LESLEY

(With sympathy.)

No...

RIGGAN
And you never will...

LESLEY
I'm sorry.

For the first time, Riggan turns to face the audience. He smiles the most beautiful insane smile.

RIGGAN
I don't exist. I'm not even here. I
don't exist. None of this matters.

Then he raises a trembling arm, and with his eyes full of tears, he aims the gun at Mike.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)
Pum.

But he doesn't shoot. Then he turns and aims at Tabitha Dickinson who is sitting on the second row.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)
Pum.

Again, no shot. Slowly, Riggan raises the gun toward his own head, suddenly a frightening explosion. Blood sprays. Riggan falls. We stay with the shell-shocked audience. A moment of tension, of uncertainty, until...

MAN
Bravo!

The audience, one by one, jump to their feet, applauding wildly. The sole exception is Tabitha, who remains seated, a dazed expression on her face. We stay with the audience a few seconds longer.

FADE TO BLACK.

The sounds slowly vanish. After a moment of silence...

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
You won't be hearing from him
anymore.

MAN (V.O.)
Is he...?

BIRDMAN (V.O.)
He's gone.

One of the old Birdman films is playing on a small television screen that hangs on a corner. The scene ends and a Morning Show host appears. Behind him a picture of Riggan and a caption that reads: "Nation in shock." A shot of a candle vigil in Central park.

HOST

What do we talk about when we talk about Riggan Thomson? When we come back, more on the actor who two nights ago shot himself during the opening performance of his new Broadway play...

We pan away from the TV to see that the waiting room is filled with newsmen waiting for something to happen. There is almost no room to breath.

We pan to see Jake emerging from an elevator, carrying a newspaper under his arm. He walks through the dense mass of newsmen with a serious expression on his face. We follow him into...

55 INT. ROOM - HOSPITAL - CONTINUOUS

55

...a room. Jake peers in. Riggan lies on a bed, the bandages on his nose cover most of his face. Sylvia is looking out the window.

JAKE

Is he...?

SYLVIA

He's awake.

Jake enters the room.

JAKE

(Serious.)

I thought I lost you, buddy. Thank god you're a horrible shot! What the hell happened? I was watching you up on that stage, and all of a sudden you get that goofy look in your eye, and you were just like--

He starts to laugh.

SYLVIA

What the hell are you laughing about? He tried to-- What is wrong with you?

JAKE

I'm happy, okay? He's alive. My best friend is alive. And he is the man of the hour!

Jake holds the New York Times up in the air.

RIGGAN

What is that?

JAKE

You did it.

SYLVIA

(Coming to them.)

You have to be shitting me... She wrote a review?

Jake unfolds the newspaper and we see the headline of the review: "The Unexpected Virtue of Ignorance".

JAKE

(To Sylvia.)

Read it.

He hands her the newspaper. She begins to read to herself.

SYLVIA

I don't believe this...

JAKE

Read it out loud!

SAM

"Thompson has unwittingly given birth to a new form that can only be described as supra-realism. Blood was spilled both literally and metaphorically by artist and audience alike. Red blood. The blood that has been sorely missing from the veins of the American theatre..."

(Beat. To a smiling Jake.)

You're happy about this?

She hands it to Riggan.

JAKE

Happy? I'm fucking euphoric This is the-- This is the kind of review that turns someone into a living legend.

SYLVIA

He tried to-- He shot the nose off his face!

JAKE

He's got a new nose! And if he doesn't like that one, we'll get him another one. We can use Meg Ryan's guy. Who gives a shit? Turn on the tv. There are people praying for him all over the country. They're lighting candles in Central Park. He did it.

(To Riggan)

You did it! The play's gonna run forever. It's gonna open in London, in Paris... The studios will call us again. We'll get book offers.

SYLVIA

How do you know all that? You can see the future?

JAKE

(Euphoric.)

Yes.

She slaps him in the face.

SYLVIA

Did you see that coming? You're so full of shit, Jake.

Jake needs a few seconds to recover. Then he looks at Riggan who just sits there, in silence.

JAKE

Why aren't you saying anything? This is what you wanted wasn't it?

(Riggan gazes at the review.)

Riggan, this is what you wanted.

RIGGAN

It's what I wanted.

JAKE

Okay, listen. You're gonna get hit with a "brandishing a weapon" charge. If anybody talks to you, it was an accident and we're doing an internal invest--

A newsman comes into the room and takes a quick picture.

JAKE (CONT'D)
 (Chasing him out.)
 This is a hospital you
 motherfucker!

Jake rushes to the door, shoving the newsman and a few other paparazzi out the door. Security guards. Chaos. Finally silence. Sylvia steps up and looks Riggan in the eye.

SYLVIA
 Is that what it was? An accident?

Riggan just stares at her. His calm, sad eyes peeking through the bandages. After a moment his gaze moves over her shoulder. Sylvia turns and we discover Sam standing in the doorway holding a bouquet of flowers. A bit of awkward silence, and Sylvia decides to leave them alone.

She kisses Sam on the head and exits. Sam walks the flowers to Riggan at the bed. She lays them on his chest.

SAM
 Alchemillas.

The hint of a smile on Riggan's face.

SAM (CONT'D)
 Are you actually smiling?
 (She smiles.)
 What's so funny?

RIGGAN
 I can't smell them.

A moment until the smiles turn to gentle laughter. She takes out her cell phone and snaps a picture of him.

RIGGAN (CONT'D)
 What are you doing?

SAM
 I'm posting this picture on your
 Twitter page.

RIGGAN
 Very funny...

SAM
 Set it up today.

RIGGAN
 You're joking.

SAM

I'm not.

RIGGAN
Let me see the picture.

SAM
Absolutely not. You look hideous.

RIGGAN
Thanks a lot.

SAM
I'm just kidding. No, I'm not. You look hideous.
(Working on phone.)
You already have 80 thousand followers. In less than a day. And I'm about to scare the shit out of them.

RIGGAN
Let me see.

SAM
No. Done.

A moment between them. Sam picks up the flowers and kisses him tenderly on the head. Riggan is pleasantly surprised by that kiss.

SAM (CONT'D)
Now, I'm going to find something to put these flowers in.

She heads out of the room. Riggan lies there for a moment, tranquil. After a moment he reaches up and touches his bandages. Finally, he climbs out of the bed. We follow him into...

56 INT. BATHROOM - ROOM - HOSPITAL - CONTINUOUS

56

...the bathroom. He stands before the mirror. He stares at his reflection for a few seconds, and slowly begins to remove the bandages. We can see that Riggan's nose has been reconstructed. It is a crooked, incomplete nose, like the one Javier Bardem has.

RIGGAN
I do look hideous.

In the reflection, Riggan sees Birdman sitting on the toilet. They look at each other, but say nothing. Riggan puts the bandages back on and we follow him out to...

57 INT. ROOM - HOSPITAL - CONTINUOUS

57

...the room. He looks around, but Sam is gone. He ambles over to the window, his ass hanging out of the back of his hospital robe. He opens the window and feels the sun and the breeze on his swollen face. We just hear the sounds of the people standing down in the parking lot. Media trucks. Fans. We stay with Riggan, who seems to be thinking about something. He sees a flock of birds dancing in the sky. Then he grabs the side of the window with one hand and begins to step up onto the sill.

The camera pans away from him to a table that has some photos propped on it: One of he and Sam when she was a child. One with Sylvia and Sam. A copy of Carver's "What we talk About When We Talk About Love" laying on the surface.

The camera continues to pan until it comes to the door. Sam enters with a small vase. She looks around...

SAM

Dad?

She goes to the bathroom and peers in... nothing.

SAM (CONT'D)

Dad...?

She spots the opened window and registers the sounds from outside. Tentatively she walks toward the window. She gets there, summons her courage and looks down. Nothing. Slowly, confused, she tilts her head up and looks up into the sky. A smile, filled with pride, begin to wash over her face.

SMASH TO BLACK